



உழவர் வாழ்வை உயர்த்தும் ஸ்டாலின் அரசு!

- 2 இலட்சம் விவசாயிகளுக்கு புதிய இலவச மின் இணைப்புகள்
- நிகர சாகுபடி பரப்பு நான்கே ஆண்டுகளில் 2.05 இலட்சம் எக்டர் உயர்வு
- 16.22 இலட்சம் மெட்ரிக் டன் உயர்ந்து உச்சம் தொட்ட உணவு தானிய உற்பத்தி

தமிழ்நாட்டின் வளர்ச்சிப் பயணத்தில் ஒருவரையும் பின்தங்க விடமாட்டோம் !!



வெல்வோம் ஒன்றாக!



MARKET MANIPULATORS ISSUE

SEBI to boost tech surveillance, use AI

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T20 WORLD CUP

Samson sizzles as India enters semifinals

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MONTHLY FIGURES

GST collection rises to over ₹1.83 lakh crore

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Iran hits Israel, U.S. bases after killing of Khamenei

Iranian authorities say over 200 people have been killed since start of the U.S. and Israeli strikes; U.S. President says he will 'be talking' to Iran leaders, while Israel pledged 'non-stop' strikes

Associated Press
Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN/DUBAI

Iran vowed revenge on Sunday after the killing of its Supreme Leader, and traded strikes with Israel as part of a widening war prompted by a U.S. and Israeli bombardment a day earlier.

U.S. President Donald Trump warned that any retaliation would only lead to further escalation. He said he would "be talking" to Iranian leaders but was vague on the timing and noted that much of the country's leadership was dead. "They want to talk, and I have agreed to talk, so I will be talking to them. They should have done it sooner," he was quoted as saying by *The Atlantic*.

Blasts in Tehran sent a



A video grab from Israeli military footage shows strikes on what it calls 'headquarters of the Iranian terror regime' in Tehran. AFP

huge plume of smoke into the sky in an area where there are government buildings. Iranian state television said that it had been targeted by strikes.

"The technical team is assessing the damage," said the broadcaster.

Iranian authorities say more than 200 people have been killed since the start of the U.S. and Israeli strikes that killed Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and other senior leaders.

Earlier, Iran fired missiles at an ever-widening

list of targets in Israel and Gulf Arab states in retaliation while Israel pledged "non-stop" strikes against Iran's leaders and military.

In Israel, loud explosions caused by missile impacts or interceptions could be heard in Tel Aviv.

Israel's rescue services said nine people were killed and 28 wounded in a strike that hit a synagogue in the central town of Beit Shemesh, bringing the overall death toll in the country to 11. The U.S. military said three service members have been killed and five seriously wounded in the Iran operation.

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Airlines cancel 350 flights; all services to 11 nations suspended

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

Indian airlines cancelled nearly 350 flights on Sunday, with Air India suspending 20 additional long-haul services to European destinations, including London, Zurich, Milan, Frankfurt and Copenhagen.

The cancellations add to the complete suspension of flights by all Indian carriers to 11 countries in West Asia, following air strikes in the region in the wake of the war between Israel-U.S. and Iran and an urgent advisory issued by the Directorate-General of Civil Aviation valid until March 2. Air India on Sunday announced 20 additional flight cancellations across Europe, taking the total number of its long-haul and ultra-long-haul services, over and above the Gulf flights, scrapped for the day to 48. This includes 28

Indians among those injured in Iranian strikes

NEW DELHI
Several Indians were among those who have been injured in the missile and drone attacks by Iran in West Asia, authorities in the UAE and Oman said. Indian missions heightened activities to address concerns of citizens scattered across West Asia. » PAGE 11

earlier cancellations affecting routes to the U.S., Canada and Europe.

The UAE's aviation regulator announced that the state would cover all accommodation and sustenance costs for the stranded passengers, ensuring continued provision of essential services, according to *Khaleej Times*.

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DMK Ministers competing with one another to indulge in scams: Modi

S. Sundar
MADURAI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday alleged that Ministers in Tamil Nadu were in a stiff competition among themselves to indulge in scams.

Sharing the dais with leaders of the BJP allies, including AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami, at a public meeting held in Madurai, he said, "Usually, Ministers compete among themselves to deliver good governance. But the DMK Ministers are competing in scams and snatching money from the poor, the youth, and the farmers. Such a corrupt government has no moral right to continue."

Assuring the people that



Poll pitch: Prime Minister Narendra Modi, along with other NDA leaders, at a public meeting held in Madurai on Sunday. G. MOORTHY

the National Democratic Alliance would ensure a clean and efficient government, he sought the ouster of the "corrupt and anti-people" DMK government.

"The DMK Mayor [in Madurai] had to resign because of corruption. The DMK was busy making money for itself, neglecting the problems of the people," Mr. Modi said. While

six lakh homes were completed under the Prime Minister's Housing Scheme, three lakh houses could not be completed in Tamil Nadu because of the failure of the DMK government to conduct the survey. "The DMK's petty politics has delayed the opportunity for the poor to live with dignity," he said.

According to him, the

DMK government exemplified corruption as opposed to the Kamaraj rule that stood for honesty. Calling the DMK government inefficient, he said Madurai fared poorly in cleanliness among similar cities.

He alleged corruption in various departments, from transfers to filling of government jobs and from sand mining contracts to Tasmac liquor bottle sale, which, he said ranged from ₹365 crore to ₹40,000 crore. "After 25 years, the DMK got absolute majority in 2021. However, it failed to deliver good governance. It looted the State and brought mafia-style politics to Madurai," he said.

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NEARBY



Stalin defends T.N. govt's stand on deepam row

CHENNAI
Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Sunday defended his government's stand on the Thirupparankundramdeepam row, saying he had decided to safeguard traditions of the hill temple. In a video message, he also reiterated his government's position upholding the two-language policy. » PAGE 6

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 17

At least 18 killed, 20 injured in blast at Nagpur factory

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

At least 18 people were killed and over 20 injured in an explosion at an ammunition manufacturing company in Raulgaon village of Nagpur district in Maharashtra on Sunday.

"Over 20 people are injured and have been shifted to nearby hospitals as well as Orange City Hospital. The bodies are yet to be identified. So far, 18 people were killed," Nagpur Rural Superintendent of Police Harsh Poddar told *The Hindu*, adding that the cause of the blast is yet to be ascertained.

The explosion occurred



Tragic incident: Rescue personnel at the site of the blast in Nagpur district on Sunday. PTI

around 7.30 a.m. in the packing area of a factory owned by SBL Energy Limited, a mining and industrial explosives manufacturer, according to police officials. The police have filed an accidental death

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» PAGE 10





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Thiru. M.K.STALIN

Hon'ble Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu



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CM

K

CH-CH

PIL plea filed at Madras HC to prevent animal slaughter at retail meat shops in city

The plea seeks a direction to ensure that slaughtering is carried out only in venues authorised by the Greater Chennai Corporation; the case will be heard by a Special Division Bench today

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

A public interest litigation petition has been filed in the Madras High Court to prevent the slaughtering of animals either within or behind the retail shops that sell mutton, chicken, or beef and ensure that it takes place only in authorised slaughterhouses of the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC).

A special Division Bench of Chief Justice Manindra Mohan Shrivastava and Justice R. Suresh Kumar is slated to hear the PIL plea during the commencement of court hearings at the Additional Heritage Court Building, which once housed the prestigious Madras Law College, from Monday.

Chennai-based activist S. Muralidharan had filed the PIL plea.

He said the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (Slaughter House) Rules, 2001 make it clear that no animal should be slaughtered within a municipal area except in a slaughter



The petitioner says the rules make it clear that no animal should be slaughtered within a municipal area except in a slaughterhouse recognised or licensed by the authorities concerned.

house recognised or licensed by the authorities concerned.

The reason for imposing such a restriction was to prevent slaughtering of animals which were pregnant or had an offspring that was less than three months old or were under the age of three months or had not been certified by a veterinarian to be in a fit condition to be slaughtered.

The 2001 Rules require the municipal authorities to establish slaughter houses where a veterinarian shall thoroughly examine,

not more than 12 animals in an hour and not more than 96 animals in a day, before issuing a fitness certificate. The rules also insist upon isolating sick animals unfit for slaughter.

Further, Rule 5 insists on making the animals rest in a lairage after the veterinary inspection and for about 24 hours before slaughtering, and Rule 6 makes it clear that no animal shall be slaughtered in the sight of other animals and no chemical, drug, or hormone should be injected before slaughter.

The rules also insist

upon stunning of animals before slaughter, bleeding and dressing of the carcasses, and state that the blood draining and collection in the slaughterhouses should be done immediately and properly. Several other conditions related to maintenance of hygiene too were a part of the statutory rules.

However, none of them gets followed properly when the animals get slaughtered at retail shops illegally.

The blood gets drained into the local stormwater drains, and the animal waste gets dumped in garbage bins, thereby posing a serious threat to the environment besides causing health hazards, the petitioner said.

He sought a direction to GCC and the Commissioner of Food Safety to strictly implement the 2001 Rules and the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006, by carrying out periodic inspections at the meat retail outlets and ensuring strict implementation of the licensing and enforcement regime.

FICCI FLO honours women achievers from various fields

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

FICCI FLO (FICCI Ladies Organisation) Chennai, the women's wing of the Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce & Industry (FICCI) honoured women from various fields for their meaningful contribution to society.

Sathya Jeganathan, paediatrician, was given the lifetime achievement award in recognition of her life-long pursuit of philanthropic service. Meena Dadha, founder, Mukti: M.S.Dadha Foundation was also given lifetime achievement award.

The awards were pre-



The FICCI FLO felicitated women from various fields for their meaningful contributions to society. J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

sented by journalist Palki Sharma, who spoke about women empowerment. She said: "Influence grows when women sponsor other women, intervene in biased moments, make clear asks without apology, challenge assumptions, de-

mand transparency, claim stretch opportunities, build strategic relationships, and put themselves forward."

With over 15,000 members nationwide, FLO provides a dynamic platform for women to connect.

Construction worker from West Bengal electrocuted

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 30-year-old construction worker was electrocuted while working at Kothavalchavadi in Chennai on Saturday.

The police said the deceased migrant worker, I. Momin from West Bengal, was engaged in construction of a bathroom on the terrace of a house in Anna Pillai street.

He slipped and fell on an overhead electric wire passing near the house and died on the spot. The police sent the body for post-mortem and are questioning the building contractor.

Pink auto drivers navigate challenges, set up their own stand at Shenoy Nagar

Meghna M.
CHENNAI

S. Logannayaki, an autorickshaw driver for 15 years, had come to the Shenoy Nagar Metro Station to drop off customers. A couple of Metro users, seeing an auto available, climbed in and asked her to wait for them. However, a male auto driver was quick to approach them and demand that they get off her auto.

"He directly told them, 'She is not part of the auto drivers' group here. There is a stand right here for us. You [customers] must take only these autos.' He didn't even look at me or address me," recalled Ms. Logannayaki.

"The customers, though frightened, fought with him. But he did not back down. Finally, they got off my auto and opted to walk rather than hire an auto at all."

Today, an autorickshaw stand just for women drivers has been opened at the very same place.

"An auto stand means security. Not just for us but



Driving change: Women drivers welcomed the formation of another dedicated stand for them. MEGHNA M.

also for customers. It gives us space to catch a breather, pick up regular customers, and to take bathroom breaks. This Shenoy Nagar auto stand has three bathrooms that women can use," said Mohana, treasurer of Veera Pengal Thoosilargal Sangam (VPTS).

A constant tussle Chennai has only two other autorickshaw stands for women drivers – at Kannaagi Nagar and Saidapet. These were opened in the

past year. The auto stand was set up with the help of the NGO Association for Non-traditional Employment for Women (Anew) and the VPTS.

Sridevi, who has been driving her pink auto for six months, noted that nowhere in the city can they stop. The male auto drivers immediately chase us away, she said.

"I parked my auto near a hotel to use the bathroom. When I came back, my auto had been moved

away. I was told the space was only for them. I won't allowed to stop even for a moment," said Ms. Sridevi, who works from 9 a.m. to 8.30 p.m. All these women auto drivers agree that the worst treatment has been at train stations as most auto unions have their stands there.

As railway stations are customer hotspots, women auto drivers are shooed away. "We can't even stop to enquire. They come to start a fight. Driving near the Tambaram station, I continue to lose a lot of customers because of this," said Pallavaram Susheela.

But for now, the drivers rejoice in the formation of another auto stand in the city.

"It has been a long-standing wish that auto stands for women are set up. I'm very happy that we now have our own space. There are over 1,500 of us spread across the city. We hope to soon set up stands for women auto drivers in their areas," Ms. Mohana added.



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Tamil Nadu

Mayor makes a splash



Buoyant start: Chennai Mayor R. Priya riding a jet ski during the inauguration of the boating facility at the new Tiruvottiyur Boat Club on Sunday. Multiple water rides and amenities await visitors at the recreational project spread over 20.17 acres set up at an estimated cost of ₹4.62 crore under the Capital Fund of Greater Chennai Corporation. R. RAGU

IIT-Madras likely to get ₹70 cr. by selling stake in firm of alumnus

Lalathendu Mishra
MUMBAI

The Indian Institute of Technology, Madras (IIT-Madras) will monetise around half of its total holding worth ₹140 crore from the forthcoming Initial Public Offering (IPO) of Indo MIM Ltd., a company which provides end-to-end solutions for the manufacture of precision engineering components for automotive, aerospace, defence, and consumer product companies using metal injection moulding (MIM) technology.

Indo MIM Ltd. promoter Krishna Chivukula, who studied in IIT-Madras has gifted 1% stake of his company to IIT-Madras acknowledging its contribution in shaping the company's current positioning as the largest manufacturer globally of precision engineering components using MIM technology.

IIT-Madras is proposing to sell up to 23,07,700 equity shares of a face value of ₹1 each out of its total holding of 46,15,385 equity

shares, which account for around 1% of the total equity capital of Indo MIM Ltd.

The value of IIT-Madras' holding is estimated at more than ₹140 crore at the expected valuation, as per market and investment banking officials.

If all IIT alumni-turned-entrepreneurs offer sweat equity to IITs in India, then they will set a good example of helping their alma mater monetize holding which could be invested in innovation labs and start-ups, analysts said.

Generally, only existing investors (private equity players, venture capitals, and promoters) get money from offer for sales (OFS), but allowing IITs to monetize through IPOs would be in the national interest, they said.

IIT-Bombay shares

In September 2024, Dr. Chivukula made one of the largest donations of ₹228 crore to IIT-Madras to be used for fellowships to top B.Tech students, eminent sportspersons, foreign students, faculty members who do high-risk research,

and to bring out a magazine, the institution had said in a press release earlier. In a related development, the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Bombay's Society for Innovation and Entrepreneurship (SINE) is set to sell 4,08,000 equity shares amounting to around ₹55 crore in the forthcoming IPO of Sedemac Mechatronics Ltd. which is scheduled to open on 4 March, 2026.

Founded in a lab at IIT Bombay in 2007, since its inception, Prof. Shashikanth Suryanarayanan, Amit Arun Dixit, Manish Sharma, and Anaykumar Avinash Joshi have built on their technical expertise to place Sedemac amongst the top players in the Integrated Starter Generator Engine Control Unit (ISG ECU) market for 2W and 3W (combined) and the largest supplier of genset controllers in India.

In 2008, the promoters (alumnus of IIT) gave 7% of their company's equity to IIT Bombay's Society for Innovation and Entrepreneurship (SINE).

City police stop VCK cadre from protesting outside U.S. Consulate

Police personnel were deployed in large numbers, and protesters who formed a procession on Peters Road were held under preventive custody

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A large number of cadre of the Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi and a group of Muslim organisations, who had joined together to protest in front of the U.S. Consulate on Anna Salai, were stopped en route on Sunday.

The outfits were planning the protest to condemn the death of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in an air strike by Israeli-U.S. forces on Sunday.

Around 200 members of the VCK, led by their leader Thol. Thirumavalavan along with Aloor Mohamed J. Shahnavas and Manithaneya Jananayaga Katchi (MJK) secretary Thammimun Ansari, tried to take out a protest in front of the U.S. Consulate.

Police personnel were posted in large numbers, and the protesters who came in a procession on Peters Road were stopped well before the Consulate premises and taken under preventive custody. The city police will be deploying additional police personnel near the U.S. Consulate from Sunday.

Mr. Thirumavalavan urged the Government of India to issue an immediate statement condemning the killing.



Manithaneya Makkal Katchi members staging a protest, led by party chief M.H. Jawahirullah, in Chennai on Sunday. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

"All those opposing American hegemony are being killed by U.S. imperialism. Saddam Hussein died in that manner. Libya's Gaddafi was killed in a grotesque manner in public. Venezuela's President was arrested. The U.S.'s imperialism has had a hand in the Egyptian revolution, Eelam killings, and recent Nepal protests," he said.

"Khamenei's stance that he would be the first to oppose U.S. imperialism had irritated them. They [imperialist forces] might have thought Khamenei would fear them after the death of Saddam Hussein, but Khamenei wasn't like that. He may have been killed, but he has won in this war. This is not a war against Iran alone, but against all nation states that are oil

INBRIEF



AIADMK district secretaries' meet to be held on March 4

The AIADMK has called for a meeting of its district unit secretaries in Chennai on March 4. A party release said that the meeting, to be chaired by party general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami, is scheduled to commence at the party head office in Chennai at 3.30 p.m.



Flights to West Asia cancelled for second day from Tiruchi

Flight services to West Asian destinations from the Tiruchi International Airport remained suspended for the second day on Sunday after tensions flared in West Asia following the military action against Iran by Israel and the U.S.

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Recovery agent held for abusing woman over non-existent borrowing

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A loan recovery agent of a private company was arrested by the West Zone Cyber Crime police for allegedly harassing and abusing a woman by demanding repayment of a loan she had never taken.

In her complaint submitted through the Cyber Crime online portal and later in person at the West Zone Cyber Crime police station, the 49-year-old woman stated that she had not taken any loan from any bank or private finance company.

However, on February 20, a man and a woman contacted her on the phone and claimed that she had taken a loan and failed to repay it. They allegedly introduced themselves as lawyers calling from the High Court and harassed her.

She further stated that on February 23, the same people contacted her again, insisting that she pay the loan amount. When she questioned why she was being repeatedly harassed, a man allegedly spoke to her in obscene and abusive language, forcing her to disconnect the call.

Based on the complaint, a case was registered at the West Zone Cyber Crime police station and taken up for investigation. A police team led by the Cyber Crime Inspector conducted an inquiry and arrested the accused, Saran, 25, of Alapakkam, Porur, who was working in a private firm in the Ambattur Industrial Estate area.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

IN LOVING MEMORY OF
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WIFE OF Mr A. RANJITHAMONY



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DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

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Dear Amma
The moment you left us, a part of us crossed the Rainbow bridge with you
All that we wish today is that we could've had one more moment together
Dr C Kamaraj
Dr Senthil Ganesh Kamaraj
Kapil Ganesh
Diya and Niku

Mrs. Hema Kamaraj
1948 - 2010

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES
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DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

DEATH ANNIVERSARY



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Tamil Nadu

President, PM, other leaders send birthday greetings to Stalin

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

President Droupadi Murmu, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Governor R.N. Ravi, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, leaders of various political parties, and actor Rajinikanth, among others, extended their birthday greetings to Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Sunday.

Mr. Stalin visited the memorials to late DMK leaders C.N. Annadurai and M. Karunanidhi, and late social reformer 'Periyar' E.V. Ramasamy, and paid floral tributes to them in the morning.

In her letter, the President, who also spoke over phone, said, "May God bless you with good health and happiness and many more years of continued and dedicated service to the nation."

Mr. Modi spoke to Mr. Stalin over phone and greeted him on his birthday. In a social media post, he said, "Best wishes to Tamil Nadu Chief Minister, Thiru M.K. Stalin, on his birthday. May he be blessed with a long life and good health."

T.N. Lok Bhavan quoted Governor Ravi as saying: "My heartfelt congratulations and best wishes to Thiru M.K. Stalin on his birthday. I pray for his

good health and happy long life."

Mr. Singh posted on social media: "Greetings and warm wishes to Tamil Nadu Chief Minister, Thiru M.K. Stalin ji. May he lead a long and healthy life."

Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, also a CPI (M) politbureau member, described Mr. Stalin as his "dear brother" and said, "Your steadfast leadership and dedication to the welfare of the people continue to be a source of inspiration. On this occasion, I also salute your unwavering resolve in protecting the democratic and secular ethos of our country against the forces of divisiveness. As we stand together to uphold the constitutional values that define our country, I wish you a year of good health, happiness, and continued success."

In a social media post, Mr. Gandhi said, "May you have good health, strength, and a long life of dedicated service to the people of Tamil Nadu."

Tamil Nadu BJP leaders Nainar Nagenthiran, Tamilisai Soundararajan, K. Anamalai and H. Rajan; DMDK general secretary Premallatha Vijayakant; Congress' State unit leaders led by K. Selvaperunthagai; PMK leader Anbumani Ramadoss; VCK leader Thol. Thirumavala; and NTK leader See-man also extended birthday greetings to the Chief Minister.

Sidelined in society and policy, trans men seek job opportunities

They say finding employment matching qualification has been difficult, forcing many to take up gig work; call for inclusive spaces, more visibility

Meghna M.
CHENNAI

Sand flew around as Sharma slid towards the midline to safeguard himself and his team in a kabaddi match. But just as he thought he had made it, the rival team members began to drag him by his feet. A gut-wrenching scream and great push later, he touched the midline to join his teammates as the crowd cheered.

Mr. Sharma, a trans man, was playing at the Trans Men Kabaddi Tournament organised by the Urimai Kural Trust in Chennai on Saturday. The tournament was an effort to increase awareness and recognition of trans men in the country. "The entire country equates trans persons with trans women. There is a lack of awareness among society and within the trans community itself on the existence of trans men. This puts us at a double disadvantage as it obscures us from not just policymaking but also education and employment opportunities," said Fred Rogers, a man of trans experience and Director of Urimai Kural Trust.

Trans men activists note that employment is the highest priority for now. M. Rahmathulla, a trans



Trans men in action during a kabaddi match held by a charitable trust on the Queen Mary's College campus. J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

man notes that finding proper employment has been difficult for them, forcing many to work as gig workers despite acquiring degrees. "When we leave our hometowns, our identification in various official documents doesn't change. So, the employers hesitate to employ us, knowing us as trans men," the 30-year-old added.

Tarun (name changed), a trans man from Chennai, pointed out that with no opportunities in their qualified field, they are pushed to taking up menial jobs. "We have all studied. I completed Mechanical Engineering but work at a bike parking spot. We are not asking for much, just jobs matching our level of education. People refuse to understand us, our families throw us out and call

us crazy," he added.

Many trans men note that they had to quit their jobs because of improper toilet facilities at the place of employment. "I quit my job when my office did not have a closed toilet and only urinals. There was no transgender bathroom. It was embarrassing and my colleagues soon found out about me. I wasn't safe anymore," says Rajesh (name changed).

He stressed that there was a need to raise awareness and make spaces more inclusive.

"While a government policy and document naming trans men and transwomen would be the best route, sensitisation meetings would help individuals be more mindful and make spaces inclusive," he added.

Naagam app to list 100 snake rescuers; more to be trained in handling reptiles

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

As many as 100 snake rescuers from across Tamil Nadu have been selected for onboarding onto the Naagam app, a new mobile platform designed to streamline snake rescue operations and strengthen scientific data collection.

Unveiled in July 2025 by senior officials of the Forest Department, the app was meant to facilitate technology-driven wildlife rescue efforts in the State.

The Forest Department has signed a Memorandum of Understanding with the Madras Crocodile Bank Trust (MCBT) to manage the application and conduct structured training programmes for rescuers.

At present, members of the public contact the Forest Department or the Tamil Nadu Fire and Rescue Service for wildlife emergencies.

The new app is expected to streamline rescue requests and ensure quicker response times, in addition to generating data to study rescue patterns and snake distribution.

Workshops conducted

So far, the MCBT has conducted workshops in Chennai, Madurai, Erode, and Coimbatore, and selected 100 rescuers with expertise in safe snake handling. Most of those

chosen are volunteers, while others are Forest Department staff.

Ch. Gnaneswar of MCBT, who is leading the training sessions, said the app would become fully effective once an additional 50 to 100 rescuers – particularly from Tier-I and Tier-II cities – are onboarded.

Currently, access to the app is limited to trained rescuers, with new features being added ahead of the public launch.

The application is modelled after SARPA, Kerala's snake rescue platform. However, Mr. Gnaneswar said Tamil Nadu was likely to receive a significantly higher volume of calls, possibly due to urbanisation and construction activities creating more hiding spaces for snakes.

Greater public awareness in Kerala about venomous and non-venomous species could also contribute to differences in rescue call volumes.

A senior Forest Department official said selected rescuers must undergo a formal application process through their respective District Forest Officers. They would be officially onboarded after thorough vetting.

The app is likely to be fully operational in four months, before the onset of the monsoon season, when there is an increase in snake rescue calls.

High demand for milk in State pushes private dairies to hike prices

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A widening gap between the demand and supply of milk in the State has led to several popular brands increasing prices of all variants. Milk industry sources said the high demand is because certain private dairies were procuring more milk than usual. This has resulted in a hike in retail prices by ₹2 or ₹3 per litre.

Milk industry expert M. Muthaiah said there is a difference of ₹16/litre between the price of Aavin full cream milk and milk from private brands. "If they increase the sale of milk at the same selling price, they will only end up losing more," he said.

T. Sadagopan, president, Tamil Nadu Progressive Consumer Centre, said a hike in milk prices would translate into a hike in prices allied products. "Consumers have no option but to buy private milk brands as Aavin sells only 15 lakh litres of milk a day in the city," he said.

S.A. Ponnusamy, Tamil Nadu Milk Dealers' Employees Welfare Association, alleged that a hike in prices was due to the failure of the State government. "The DMK government shelved the free cattle scheme introduced by former Chief Minister Jayalithaa, which has led to the current sorry state of affairs," he alleged.

Ensure safety of Tamils in West Asia, says EPS

CHENNAI: AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Sunday urged the Central government to initiate measures to ensure the safety of Tamils living in various West Asian nations. In a social media post, he appealed to all Indians and Tamils in West Asian countries to remain safe.

**CHENNAI UNIFIED METROPOLITAN TRANSPORT AUTHORITY (CUMTA)**
(An Authority under Government of Tamil Nadu)
7th Floor, Metros, No.327, Anna Salai, Nandanam, Chennai-600 035
Email: cumtaoffice@tn.gov.in, Ph.No. 044-24322377

Description	Period	Last date and time of submission	Opening
CUMTA/Admin/Vehicle Hiring/Rate contract/2026, Dt.02.03.2026 - Selection of an agency for providing office vehicles on hiring on rate contract basis for a period of 3 years	02.03.2026 to 30.03.2026	30.03.2026 @ 03.00 PM	30.03.2026 @ 04.00 P.M.

For details visit www.tntenders.gov.in and CUMTA website : www.cumta.tn.gov.in
DIPR/ 1453 /Tender/2026

Member Secretary, CUMTA

कार्यालय अतिरिक्त मुख्य अभियन्ता सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग सम्भार-प्रथम, उदयपुर
क्रमांक:- ACE/NTT/2025-26/D-756 दिनांक: 24/02/2026

निविदा संख्या- 23/2025-26

राजस्थान के राज्यपाल महोदय की ओर से भवन निर्माण कार्य हेतु उपर्युक्त श्रेणी में सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग राजस्थान में पंजीकृत संवेद्यकों एवं राज्य सरकार/केन्द्र सरकार के अधिकृत संयन्त्रों/ केन्द्रीय लोक निर्माण विभाग/दाक एवं दूर संचार विभाग/लेवे इन्वार्ड में पंजीकृत संवेद्यकों, जो कि राजस्थान सरकार के ए. ए. श्रेणी के संवेद्यकों के समकक्ष हों, से निर्धारित प्रथम में भवन निर्माण कार्य के लिए ई-प्रोक्वेस्ट प्रक्रिया से ऑनलाईन निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती है।

कार्य का नाम	कुल 1 (एक) भवन कार्य
निविदा की कुल लागत	एरि र. 1456.00 लाख
ऑनलाईन निविदा आवेदन डाउनलोड एवं अपलोड करने की तारीख	05.03.2026 प्रातः 9:30 बजे से 24.03.2026 सायं 6.00 बजे तक
ऑनलाईन निविदा खोलने की तारीख	27.03.2026 सायं 4.00 बजे से

निविदा से सम्बन्धित विवरण वेबसाईट <http://dipr.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> व sppp.rajasthan.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है। सम्पूर्ण निविदा प्रक्रिया <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> पर ऑनलाइन सम्पादित की जावेगी।
NIB Code:- PWD2526A5873, UBN: PWD2526WLO824297
DIPR/C/4368/2026 अतिरिक्त मुख्य अभियन्ता, का.नि.वि. सम्भार-प्रथम उदयपुर



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**INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY, CHENNAI - 38**
INDIAN RAILWAYS

TENDER Notice No. ICF/EL/Cons/2025-26, dt.02.03.2026
For and on behalf of The President of India, The Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer / Maintenance / Shell, Integral Coach Factory, invites E - Tender for the following works.

Tender No.	Name of the work	Approx. Value in Lakhs Rs.	EMD (Rupees)	Tender Closing Date and Time
(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
2026245212079R	EL-W-922 Electrical works for Improvements to compound wall around D & D Building	71.54	1,43,100/-	23.03.2026 at 15.30 hrs.
2025245211795R3	EL-M-W-183 Raising of Electrical Control Panel above 450 mm from the ground level at LHB & FUR.	15.01	30,000/-	23.03.2026 at 15.30 hrs.

Website for submission of offer: www.ireps.gov.in
Hindi version of the above tender notification is available in: <https://icf.indianrailways.gov.in>

**ICF HOSPITAL, CHENNAI - 600 038.**

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST
Principal Chief Medical Officer, Integral Coach Factory, Chennai-600 038 invites Application in sealed cover for empanelment for the treatment including investigations / Procedures as per CGHS rates for ICF beneficiaries from the Private Hospitals who are interested to participate, on or before **23.03.2026 at 11.00 hours** to the office of the Principal Chief Medical Officer, Integral Coach Factory Hospital, Chennai-600 038.

1.	Tender Notice No.	No.MD/ICF/34/Recog. Dt. 27.02.2026
2.	Name of the E.O.I.	Empanelment of Multispeciality, Single speciality Hospitals for the treatment including procedures / investigations as per CGHS Rates.
3.	Eligibility.	All Hospital empanelled with CGHS, ECHS & ESI Multispeciality and Single speciality Hospitals and other hospitals willing to accept the rates prescribed by the Central Government Health Scheme presently in vogue.
4.	Terms and Conditions.	To be downloaded from the below mentioned website.
5.	Period of Empanelment.	Two years from the date of acceptance of your Expression of Interest (As per Empanelment schedule)
6.	Date and time for submission of EO.I.	Up to 11.00 hrs. on 23.03.2026
7.	Date and time for opening of Tender	At 11.30 hrs. on 23.03.2026
8.	Website Address.	http://www.icf.indianrailways.gov.in

Phone No. : 044-26146633, 26146639 & 26146640.
Principal Chief Medical Officer
For and on behalf of the President of India

**INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY, CHENNAI - 38**

Tender Notice No. ICF/PCMM/EOT/09/2026. Dated: 27.02.2026
The following e-tenders are published in IREPS website. Firms are requested to login to www.ireps.gov.in and quote against these tenders. Manual quotations will not be entertained for these tenders. Closing and Opening time for all tenders are 14.15 hrs. Hindi version of tender notice is available on website www.icf.indianrailways.gov.in

Sl. No.	Tender No.	Tender Title	Quantity	Due Date / Time
01.	08252289C	Gear Wheel for 1400 HP DEMU	8 Nos	13.03.2026
02.	05261004	Aluminium Extrusions & Mouldings for Amrit Bharat Coaches	75 Sets	16.03.2026
03.	08261182	S & I of EPDM Assembly for Kolkata Metro TRCC Cables	8 Sets	17.03.2026
04.	02261070	Adapter / Rescue Couplers for Amrit Bharat	450 Nos	17.03.2026
05.	07261190	S & I of SS Panels and Mouldings for Side Wall	35 Sets	19.03.2026
06.	08261114	Cable 1.5 Sq.mm, Black, Yellow, GNYE, Blue, Chocolate & Red	419000 Nos	24.03.2026
07.	08261063	S & I Cable Trays NDMC2 MEMU OB 12	34 Sets	02.04.2026

CORRIGENDUM No.09
Corrigendum has been issued to the following tender. Please check IREPS website for further details.

Sl. No.	Tender No.	Existing Value	Modified Value
01.	02261001	Modification of Item Description, Additions and Deletion of Drawing. Please refer Tender Document for details in IREPS website.	
02.	03260010	23.02.2026	20.03.2026

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CM YK A CH-CHE

Tamil Nadu

From Page One

Modi accuses DMK Ministers of competing to indulge in scams

Taking a jibe at the Congress, Mr. Modi said that angered by Tamil Nadu having rejected the party, it “took revenge” by handing over Katchatheevu to Sri Lanka and banning “jallikattu”.

He took credit for lifting the ban on the bull-taming sport.

‘DMK, Cong. neglected Pamban Bridge’

Referring to the Pamban Bridge, he said the old rail bridge had worn out, forcing the trains to run slowly across the sea. It should have been replaced earlier, but the DMK and the Congress, which were in power at the Centre for 10 years since 2004, failed to act, the Prime Minister alleged.

After the NDA came to power, the work was expedited and trains were now running faster on the bridge, he said. “The DMK and the Congress did nothing for Tamil Nadu, but talked big,” the Prime Minister said.

‘Growing drug mafia’

Accusing the DMK government of failing to curb crimes against women, Mr. Modi said families were being destroyed by a growing drug mafia.

“The NDA government that is to be elected will ensure the safety, dignity, and empowerment of women,” he added.

Trade agreement with EU

The Prime Minister said India’s trade agreement with the European Union would create golden opportunities for the youth, the farmers, and the entrepreneurs of Tamil Nadu.

He said the textile, electronics, and manufacturing sectors, and seafood exporters would gain access to global markets. Factories would expand and the farmers and the workers would get new job opportunities. Tamil Nadu’s products would have a greater chance of competing globally.

“For all these to happen, Tamil Nadu needs a government focused on the people’s welfare,” he said. The NDA, he added, would provide a stable and people-oriented government.

Stalin says he decided to save traditions of Madurai hill temple

Chief Minister justifies his government’s stand in Thirupparankundram *deepam* issue through a video message; reiterates its two-language policy

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister and DMK president M.K. Stalin on Sunday justified his government’s stand on the Thirupparankundram *deepam* row saying he had decided to safeguard the traditions of the hill temple in Madurai.

Through a video message disseminated by the DMK, Mr. Stalin sought to explain how his government took a stand in the Thirupparankundram temple issue. He also reiterated his government’s position of upholding the two-language policy.

“I decided to safeguard the traditions of the Thirupparankundram temple. I did not do so as a religious leader, but as a Chief Minister. I firmly believe personal faith should not bow down to politics,” Mr. Stalin said in the video clipping.

Rationalism did not demand constant fights with faith, Mr. Stalin said and contended: “Both are two faces of the same society. The friendship between Periyar (E.V. Ramasamy)



I did not do so [make the decision] as a religious leader, but as a Chief Minister. I firmly believe personal faith should not bow down to politics

M.K. STALIN
T.N. Chief Minister

and Adigalar is proof of that.”

In politics, Mr. Stalin said his goal was to unite everyone. “We may have different beliefs, but we live in the same land. We speak the same language. We walk towards the same future. That is the throbbing pulse of the Dravidian movement.”

He reiterated his government’s two-language policy. “The importance given to the Hindi language has not only belittled other languages, but also destroyed them,” he said.

“The BJP government seeks to make Hindi not only the official language but also the language of authority in this country. They ordered us to teach three languages to our children. Impossible! We will safeguard Tamil and En-

GLISH. There is no change on that front. Our mother tongue is our soul; English is our window to the world,” he added.

Mr. Stalin further said, “Fighting the Governor has been the first chapter of every welfare scheme we implement. As far as the Dravidian model goes, this is a non-negotiable price.”

Hailing his late father and former Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi as a “great personality”, Mr. Stalin said: “I cannot write like him. Neither can I speak like him. But what can I do? I can work like him. I can work for the people. For now, that is enough.”

Referring to attempts to test him and his party, the Chief Minister said: “Our sweat and tears went into building the Dravidian Model. We will safeguard it.”

Deepam issue: A-G denies consent to initiate contempt action against retired judge

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Advocate-General (A-G) P.S. Raman has desisted from granting consent to initiate criminal contempt of court proceedings against retired Madras High Court judge, Justice D. Hariparanthaman, for his comments against Justice G.R. Swaminathan of the High Court pursuant to an order passed by the latter on the Thirupparankundram *Karthigai Deepam* issue in December 2025.

The A-G wrote, “I have seen the statements made [by Justice Hariparanthaman] and I may state that I do not personally concur or even approve of the views expressed therein.” Nevertheless, he desisted from granting consent, as required under Section 15 (1)(b) of the Contempt of Courts Act, 1971, after referring to the right to freedom of speech and expression and the right to criticism.

“Since the statements have been made by a retired Judge of the High Court who knows his responsibility, without expressing any opinion on whether his comments amounted to bringing the institution to disrepute, or whether the same attribute motives to a conduct of a



D. Hariparanthaman

Judge, exercising my judicial discretion, I deem it fit to drop these proceedings,” the A-G wrote in his quasi-judicial order.

He, however, left it open to the applicant, Srirangam-based temple activist Rangarajan Narasimhan, “to pursue this matter if he so desires by moving the Hon’ble Madras High Court directly”. The applicant had sought consent by referring to interviews of the retired judge published on two YouTube channels on December 4 and 6, 2025.

Submitting a transcript of these Tamil interviews, the applicant said the retired judge had said, in one of the interviews, that “everyone knows that he [Justice Swaminathan] is a Sanghi. Like how I am a Communist, he is a Sanghi”. The A-G perused the interviews and also the transcripts. Referring to an instance of the A-G having

recused himself from hearing a plea to grant consent to initiate criminal contempt proceedings against retired Supreme Court judge Markandey Katju since they both were known to each other, Mr. Raman said he did not face any such embarrassment since Mr. Hariparanthaman was known to him only as a judge and a fellow lawyer before his elevation.

Stating that the point for consideration before him was to find out whether the two interviews amounted to a contemptuous conduct, the A-G said, “When persons who have themselves been holding constitutional posts are accused of criminal contempt for public statements made by them regarding the conduct of the judiciary or any particular Judge, more care is desired to be taken by the sanctioning authority.”

Mr. Raman went on to state, “While I believe that eminent persons, particularly those who have been in high constitutional posts, need to be restrained in their comments about the functioning of the judiciary or of any particular Judge, the same has also got to be viewed in the context of freedom of speech and expression, and in particular, the right of criticism.”

Collective goal is ‘developed T.N. for developed India’: PM

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi laid the foundation stone for development projects worth more than ₹4,400 crore in Madurai on Sunday. He said, “Our collective goal is a developed Tamil Nadu for developed India.”

Speaking at the function held at Madurai Airport, Mr. Modi said the new projects were aimed at transforming connectivity, boosting economy, and creating significant job opportunities for the youth.

He emphasised that building high-quality infrastructure was fundamentally about empowering people.

“These developments mean better roads for farmers to reach the markets, easier travel for pilgrims and tourists, and faster transport for businesses,” he said.

He said that over the past 12 years (since 2014), the Union government had made significant investments in Tamil Nadu’s



Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Governor R.N. Ravi, AIADMK leader Edappadi K. Palaniswami, BJP State president Nainar Nagenthiran, and others at an event held in Madurai on Sunday.

highway network, with more than 4,000 km of highways constructed.

Mr. Modi laid the foundation stone for two significant National Highway projects – the four-laning of the Marakkanam-Puducherry section at an investment of ₹2,100 crore to boost coastal trade and tourism, and the expansion of the Paramakudi-Ramanathapuram stretch.

“With an investment of more than ₹1,800 crore, the latter project will significantly enhance access to places such as Rameswa-

ram and Dhanushkodi, ensuring ease of travel for pilgrims and smoother transport of agricultural and marine products,” he said.

The Prime Minister underscored that over the last decade, the Indian Railways had undergone a historic transformation, emerging as a modern, efficient, and people-centric transport system.

“This transformation is particularly visible in Tamil Nadu, where the Railway Budget allocation has increased nearly nine-fold

since the current government took office,” the Prime Minister said.

“While the average yearly allocation was ₹880 crore between 2009 and 2014, it has risen to ₹7,600 crore for 2026-27,” Mr. Modi pointed out.

He said that more than 1,300 km of new tracks had been laid in the State, 97% electrification achieved, and the construction of hundreds of flyovers and underpasses had improved safety and efficiency.

“Currently, nine Vande

Bharat and Amrit Bharat trains each are serving the people of Tamil Nadu, with their coaches being manufactured at the Integral Coach Factory in Chennai,” he said.

“Under the Amrit Bharat Station scheme, 77 railway stations in the State are being modernised to blend comfort, accessibility, and local identity. The Chennai Beach-Chennai Egmore fourth line will benefit thousands of daily commuters,” he said.

Mr. Modi highlighted that infrastructure funding for Tamil Nadu had tripled compared to the previous decade, noting that the 2026 Union Budget maintains this trend, with a strong focus on the State.

Detailing proposals for the Bengaluru-Chennai and Chennai-Hyderabad bullet train corridors, he pointed out, “The Budget positions Tamil Nadu within the Rare Earth Corridors, aimed at promoting advanced manufacturing, research, and technology development.”

Stating that Tamil Nadu

possessed a rich history and heritage, the Prime Minister announced that historic sites such as Adichanallur would be developed into global heritage destinations.

“Ecotourism initiatives around Pulicat lake and Pothigai Malai will create new job opportunities, while preserving natural ecosystems,” he said.

Approximately 200 industrial clusters will be identified and supported nationwide to boost manufacturing, significantly benefiting the local youth, he added.

“Every Indian is inspired to build a developed nation by 2047. Tamil Nadu will play a decisive role in shaping the nation’s destiny,” he added.

Mr. Modi also inaugurated *Akashvani*’s new FM relay transmitters in Kumbakonam, Yercaud, and Vellore.

Governor R.N. Ravi, Minister for Public Works and Highways E.V. Velu, Leader of the Opposition Edappadi K. Palaniswami, among others, participated.

DMK’s offer of 25 seats not acceptable, says Congress leader

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The AICC in-charge for Tamil Nadu and head of the party’s seat-sharing negotiation committee for the upcoming Assembly election, Girish Chodankar, on Sunday said the 25 seats offered by the DMK to the Congress was not acceptable.

“We have been associated with the DMK for a very long time. Whenever they were in a crisis, we reduced our quota. Now, it is their turn,” he said.

While the committee was scheduled to resume negotiations on Monday, sources in the DMK indicated on Sunday that it may not happen as Mr. Chodankar had left for Goa.

In an interview to ANI, Mr. Chodankar said the committees formed by the DMK and the Congress had an “hour-long” discussion

(on Saturday), and hoped the Congress’s demands would be accepted.

According to him, the committee is following the lead of the Tamil Nadu Congress leaders, who met party leader Rahul Gandhi in New Delhi recently.

Mr. Chodankar said he hoped the party’s wish list, submitted to the DMK, would be accepted, as “only then we can continue with this (negotiations)”.

Missing warmth

Meanwhile, the “brotherly warmth” appeared to be missing in Mr. Gandhi’s birthday greetings to DMK leader and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin. Last year, in a social media post, Mr. Gandhi had addressed Mr. Stalin as “my brother”, and the latter had thanked his “dear brother”. But this time, the greetings and the response were formal, with the word “brother” conspicuously absent.

DMK is spreading false propaganda against Union govt., says Palaniswami

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

The ruling DMK was spreading false propaganda that Tamil Nadu was not receiving development support from the Union government, said AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami here on Sunday.

Addressing an election meeting organised by the NDA, Mr. Palaniswami said, “Even today, the Prime Minister flagged off development works worth ₹4,400 crore to Tamil Nadu.”

According to him, every time the Prime Minister visited the State, thousands of crores were allotted to

Tamil Nadu for development projects. But the DMK was spreading false propaganda for political reasons. “Can the Chief Minister, Mr. Stalin, list what development the DMK brought to the State when it was part of the Union government? What benefits did the people of the State receive through them?” he asked.

He further alleged that members of the Chief Minister’s family, who were previously Ministers in the Union government, were involved in corruption. “DMK’s is the only government that was dissolved due to corruption,” he said.

Mr. Palaniswami also

credited the AIADMK, which was in power cumulatively for 31 years, for Tamil Nadu’s development.

He said the erstwhile AIADMK government had secured approval for 11 government medical colleges for the State in one phase, adding, “The DMK has not been able to create even one medical college now.”

He also said that the Centre had sanctioned the new Pamban rail bridge and undertaken the expansion of Thoothukudi Airport and port.

Pattali Makkal Katchi leader Anbumani Ramadoss said the five-year rule of the DMK had buried social justice in Tamil Nadu, and criticised the govern-

ment for failing to conduct a caste-based census, as was done in Bihar.

BJP State president Nainar Nagenthiran, Tamil Maanila Congress leader G.K. Vasan, and AMMK founder T.T.V. Dhinakaran, condemned the increase in crimes in the State.

K. Annamalai, former BJP State president, said the DMK government’s claim of having achieved 11.19% GDP growth was due to the Centre’s productivity-linked incentive scheme. Piyush Goyal and L. Murugan (BJP), John Pandian (TMMK), T.R. Paarivendhar (IJK), and A.C. Shanmugam (New Justice Party) were among the participants.

More than 8 lakh students to appear for Class 12 State Board exams today

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A total of 8,27,475 candidates have registered to appear for the Class 12 State Board exam, which will begin with the language examination on Monday. This includes 7,99,692 school students and 27,783 private candidates.

A total of 281 prisoners will also appear for the public exam.

Over 49,000 teachers will be deployed for the examination, which will be conducted across 3,412 centres in the State.

More than 4,900 flying squads will also be deployed to prevent malpractice across the State.



Over 49,000 teachers will be deployed for the examination, which will be conducted across 3,412 centres in the State. FILE PHOTO

The examination will be held from 10 a.m. to 1.15 p.m.

In Chennai, a total of 64,359 boys and 33,696 girls will appear for the exams being conducted at 250 centres, including the

special examination centre at the Puzhal Central Prison.

According to a release, five question paper storage centres, five answer paper collection centres, and 65 routes have been set up to

transport the question papers to the examination centres.

A total of 6,150 people – 250 Chief Invigilators, 250 departmental officers, 550 Flying Squad members, 4,100 invigilators and scribes, and 1,000 support staff – have been deployed for the exams.

Chief Minister M.K. Stalin in a social media post wrote: “All the best to the Class 12 students who will be writing their public exams tomorrow. Face the exam without stress, and succeed. Opportunities are pouring in for you. Study with determination, and our Dravidian Model government is there to encourage and uplift you.”

INBRIEF



Forest fire at Horsley Hills in A.P. brought under control

A forest fire that erupted in the Horsley Hills reserve forest in Annamayya district of Andhra Pradesh was brought under control on Sunday after a sustained firefighting operation. Officials said the blaze, first detected on February 26, is believed to have spread from the Karnataka side into the reserve forest. While no wildlife losses have been reported so far, preliminary estimates indicate that nearly 50 hectares of forest area, predominantly wild grass, were affected.

CM opens Phase I of Wayanad township, 178 families get keys

Hailing the reconstruction efforts in landslides-hit Wayanad as the latest instance of the ‘Kerala model,’ where people beyond all religious differences come together to support each other in distress, Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan on Sunday inaugurated the first phase of the Kalpetta township, built for the survivors of the Mundakkai-Chooralmala landslides in July 2024. Keys to houses were handed over to 178 families.

YSRCP asks TTD chairman to resign over ‘sleaze video’

The YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) has demanded the removal of Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD) chairman B.R. Naidu following some video clips purportedly showing him in a bad light going viral on social media. “An individual facing such moral allegations is unfit to hold a sacred position,” party leader Bhumana Karunakar Reddy said. Mr. B.R. Naidu took exception to the alleged sleaze video and warned of action against those spreading smear campaign against him.

Fireworks unit blast exposes laxity in ensuring safety steps

Rules recommended by the inquiry panel in the aftermath of a deadly firecracker accident in A.P. last year had reportedly not been followed leading to a second tragedy in barely five months

M. Sambasiva Rao
AMARAVATI

In the wake of the accident that killed 20 people at the Sri Surya Firecrackers complex at Vetlapalem village in Kakinada district of Andhra Pradesh on Saturday, serious questions have resurfaced on the implementation of the Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) recommended by a two-member Inquiry Committee constituted by the Andhra Pradesh government in October last year.

Despite comprehensive directions, accidents continue to occur, allegedly due to non-compliance by both enforcement agencies and manufacturers. Most of the rules prescribed by the committee were reportedly not followed by Sri Surya Fire Crackers, underscoring systemic lapses.

The committee was formed following a devastating explosion at Sri Ganapathi Grand Fireworks in Rayavaram village of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar Konaseema district on October 8, 2025, which claimed 10 lives and caused extensive property damage.

The committee proposed a two-tier framework – policy reforms and operational SOPs. It called for a unified digital portal, the Andhra Pradesh Fireworks Licensing and Monitoring System (APFLMS), integrating licensing, inspections and compliance tracking across depart-



Twenty people died in a blast at a firecrackers unit in Kakinada district, Andhra Pradesh on Saturday. PTI

ments. Joint inspections by Petroleum and Explosives Safety Organisation (PESO), Fire Services, Labour and District Administration were made mandatory.

A composite Fireworks Operation Licence, risk-based categorisation and a Fireworks Risk Index (FRI) were recommended to prioritise high-risk units.

The District Fireworks Safety Committee (DFSC), chaired by the Collector, is tasked with quarterly inspections, maintaining a district risk register, and suspending licences for persistent violations.

The committee’s warning was unequivocal: without strict adherence by both government machinery and manufacturers, regulatory provisions will remain on paper and preventable tragedies will continue to claim lives.

Firecracker business thrives amid safety concerns, demand

M. Sambasiva Rao
AMARAVATI

The multi-crore firecracker manufacturing business has come under sharp focus following the accident at a firecracker factory in Kakinada district on Saturday.

The tragedy has once again drawn attention to the rapid expansion of the sector, driven by soaring demand across Andhra Pradesh.

As the demand steadily rises, firecracker units are spreading across the length and breadth of the State, transforming the

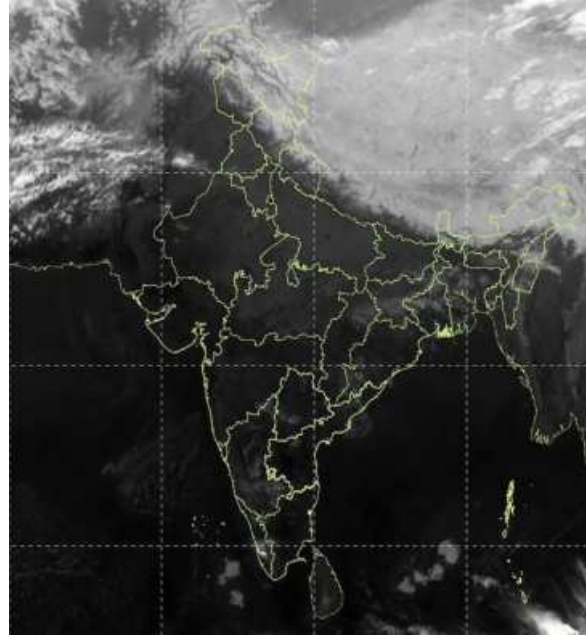
sector into a quick multi-crore enterprise, generating revenue and employment.

However, with expansion comes responsibility. Observers stress that while the industry should be encouraged for its economic contribution and employment generation, the government must strictly enforce safety regulations to prevent recurring accidents and protect lives.

It is also observed that the prices of firecrackers are often fixed at five to 10 times of their actual value, which provides huge margins for the sellers.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Strong surface winds (speed reaching 20-30 kmph) very likely over Haryana, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		32.2	19.3	Kozhikode		35.0	24.8
Ahmedabad		34.2	21.2	Kurnool		37.0	24.0
Aizawl		31.0	11.0	Lucknow		32.5	16.0
Allahabad		32.8	17.2	Madurai		36.6	20.9
Bengaluru		19.2	19.2	Mangaluru		31.8	23.2
Bhopal		15.1	15.1	Mumbai		31.8	21.5
Bhubaneswar		36.2	23.2	Mysuru		33.2	20.6
Chandigarh		29.1	12.1	New Delhi		30.8	14.4
Chennai		33.7	23.4	Patna		31.4	19.1
Coimbatore		34.4	21.6	Port Blair		30.6	23.1
Dehradun		29.7	12.8	Puducherry		32.2	22.6
Gangtok		12.1	9.3	Pune		35.2	18.7
Goa		32.4	20.8	Raipur		35.6	22.2
Guwahati		26.6	18.2	Ranchi		30.8	12.0
Hubballi		35	18.3	Shillong		20.2	8.4
Hyderabad		34.8	21.5	Shimla		18.5	9.2
Imphal		26.2	9.5	Srinagar		21.0	1.4
Jaipur		18.0	18.0	Thiruvananthapuram		4.0	33.6
Kochi		31.0	25.6	Tiruchi		35.1	22.4
Kohima		18.5	9.2	Vijayawada		35.5	23.0
Kolkata		33.6	33.6	Visakhapatnam		31.0	23.8

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing							Yesterday
CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	
Ahmedabad		27	58	41		88	145
Bengaluru		25	12	24		62	114
Chennai		6	13	52		131	146
Delhi		87	26		166	144	144
Hyderabad		15	12	61		66	108
Kolkata		8	74	39		99	100
Lucknow		5	28	32		206	125
Mumbai		3	21	21		33	95
Pune		96	40		58	84	84
Visakhapatnam		47	91	30		144	158

<

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Making the grade



Next in line: NCC cadets awaiting their turn for the NCC B certificate examination organised at Dr. Lankapalli Bullayya College in Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh on Sunday. V. RAJU

CJI lays foundation for court complex in A.P., says judiciary must build public trust

N.S. Chowdary
TIRUPATI

The Bar and the Bench have equal responsibility to instil confidence among the people that they will get security and justice in the courts, said Chief Justice of India Surya Kant.

He was addressing the media after laying the foundation stone for a new court complex at Daminedu in Tirupati Rural Mandal of Andhra Pradesh on Sunday.

Judges of the Supreme Court and the Andhra Pradesh High Court participated in the event.

On the occasion, the CJI said: “I have always said that court complexes



Chief Justice of India Surya Kant at the Judicial Academy building foundation stone event in Amaravati. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

should function like hospitals. Just like a patient is given primary treatment as soon as he goes to a hospital, every person who comes to the court should feel confident that justice will be delivered.”

He said he wanted the new court complex to become a temple of justice.

“I want every person who comes here to leave with the joy of getting justice,” Mr. Surya Kant said, wishing the Tirupati Bar

Association to further develop its intelligence, historical heritage and intellectual property.

On Bar and Bench
The Bar and the Bench are not rivals, they are two arms of the same institution, he added.

“A strong Bar Association provides good arguments, which motivate the judges to think more deeply, analyse carefully and write clear judgments. Its support will enhance the performance of the judges. This will increase the faith of the public in the judiciary. I wish the new court complex to provide a suitable working environment for the advocates,” he said.

Talks on CPI(M) candidates enter final stages in Kannur ahead of Assembly election in Kerala

The Hindu Bureau
KANNUR

The Communist Party of India (Marxist) Kannur district secretariat has ramped up preparations for the Assembly election in Kerala with a broad understanding reportedly reached on candidates in eight constituencies in the district.

Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan is set to seek a third consecutive term from Dharmadam and is expected to lead the Left Democratic Front (LDF) campaign in the State.

Sources suggest that the MLAs for several constituencies will be fielded again, despite controversies surrounding some leaders.

In Payyannur, Kallias-



Poll parley: While Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan is set to seek a third straight term from Dharmadam, CPI(M) State secretary M.V. Govindan is unlikely to contest again from Taliparamba. FILE PHOTO

sery, and Azhikode, where incumbents have completed one term, no changes are expected. T.I. Madhusoodanan is likely to be fielded again from Payyanur, while M. Vijin and K.V. Sumesh are likely to contest again from Kalliasery and Azhikode, respectively.

Payyannur has emerged as a focal point amid allegations of fund misappropriation that rocked the party locally.

Shifting seats
CPI(M) State secretary M.V. Govindan is unlikely to contest again from Taliparamba. Instead, the names

of All India Democratic Women’s Association leaders P.K. Shyamala and N. Sukanya are under consideration.

In Mattannur, DYFI State secretary V.K. Sanoj is expected to enter the fray, with the party leadership not keen on fielding former Health Minister K.K. Shailaja, MLA, again. Though she was reluctant to contest from any constituency other than Mattannur, she has reportedly agreed to contest from Peravoor, a stronghold of the Congress.

In Thalassery, with Speaker A.N. Shamseer completing two terms, Karayi Rajan is expected to contest.

In Koothuparamba, there is a strong demand within a section of the local

CPI(M) to reclaim the seat, which it held in 2016. However, Rashtriya Janata Dal’s K.P. Mohanan, who won in 2021 as part of the Left Democratic Front, is seeking re-election. A faction within the RJD has also suggested P.K. Praveen, a relative of Mr. Mohanan and the party’s State general secretary, as a potential candidate.

However, no change is likely in Kannur, where Ramachandran Kadannappally, MLA, is poised to contest for a third consecutive term as the LDF candidate.

In the last Assembly polls, the CPI(M) secured majorities exceeding 20,000 votes in all the constituencies it contested in Kannur, except in Azhikode and Peravoor.

Former Maoist leader returns to hometown in Telangana, meets kin after four decades

P. Sridhar
PEDDAPALLI

Former Maoist leader Mallojula Venugopal Rao, alias Abhay, who returned to the mainstream in October last year, visited his native Peddapalli town in Telangana on Sunday, evoking feelings of nostalgia among his relatives and childhood friends.

The excitement was palpable among local residents, who received Mr. Rao warmly on his arrival in his native town after a gap of more than four decades.

The 69-year-old former top-ranking Maoist leader, who had spent nearly 44 years underground, surrendered before the Maha-



Down memory lane: Mallojula Venugopal Rao (middle) with his relatives in Peddapalli town on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ashtra police on October 14, 2025.

He was known as a key strategist in the banned CPI (Maoist). He held crucial posts such as the secretary of the outlawed organisation’s Central Regional Bureau and official spokesperson.

He, along with his elder

brother, slain Maoist leader Koteswara Rao alias Kishenji, were known as ‘Mallojula brothers’ among the naxal ranks.

Sources added that he was accompanied by around half-a-dozen police personnel in plainclothes from Maharashtra during the visit.



Imperial war

American and Israeli thuggery has no place in the international system

Donald Trump came to the White House promising to end America's endless wars. That promise now lies in ashes in West Asia. The far-right Republican, who, along with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, launched an all-out war against Iran on February 28 and killed its Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, has proved to be one of the most reckless warmongers ever to occupy the Oval Office. Blood is on the hands of these two men – one a mercurial hard nationalist who is turning America into a rogue superpower, and the other, an expansionist ethnonationalist wanted for war crimes by the International Criminal Court. Mr. Trump has bombed at least seven countries in the 13 months that he has been in office. Under Mr. Netanyahu, Israel has operated far outside the boundaries of international law. Iran has responded with missile and drone attacks, targeting Israeli and American bases in the Persian Gulf and Jordan, that risks widening the war. Tehran has also announced the closure of the critical Strait of Hormuz, a move that risks a global economic fallout, especially for major oil importers such as India.

To be clear, this is not a “pre-emptive” war, as Israel has claimed. There was no evidence that Iran was preparing to launch an attack. On the contrary, Tehran was involved in serious negotiations with Washington under Omani mediation. On February 27, Oman's Foreign Minister Badr al-Busaidi said that a deal was within reach, based on Iran's commitment not to build a bomb or stockpile nuclear material. Within hours, American and Israeli missiles struck Iran, killing its head of state and top leaders. This is not the first time that diplomacy has been overtaken by force. In 2018, Mr. Trump single-handedly sabotaged the 2015 nuclear agreement. In June 2025, while Iran was negotiating with the U.S., Israel launched a unilateral attack, triggering the 12-day war. This time, however, the attack is far more dangerous. This war is not about giving Iranians their “freedom” either, as Mr. Trump has claimed. The U.S. maintains close ties with several repressive monarchies and dictatorships, where freedom rarely enters the equation. Nor has Washington shown any qualms about Israel's crimes against the defenceless, stateless Palestinian people. This is a war of choice, launched to eliminate an adversary and reshape the region to suit American and Israeli interests. Such thuggery cannot be accepted in the international system. The war machines of the imperial duo have already wrecked the region. Before the fire spreads further, this war must end. America should step back and Israel must be reined in. Otherwise, even the last vestige of the rules-based order will be shredded entirely.

Selective outrage

Judiciary seems quick to take offence only when it sees itself under attack

The Supreme Court Bench that took up the NCERT Class 8 social science textbook case might have overreacted when it saw the critical references to the judiciary as a “deep-seated conspiracy” and declared that it will not allow “anyone on earth” to tarnish the judiciary's integrity. While the government has expressed remorse, Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's statement that action will be taken against officials responsible for inserting references to case pendency and “judicial corruption” is an exercise in executive arbitrariness prompted by judicial overreach. In fairness to the Court, it would likely not have taken offence to the passages had these had been in any other book. But textbooks are official, authoritative accounts and the judiciary found the passages ill-motivated. Instances of judicial corruption are real and censoring textbooks is not a corrective measure.

Since the BJP came to power, rewriting school and college textbooks has been a key part of its agenda. Right-wing commentators often find court judgments, such as those giving precedence to the environment as against development, or worse, as against religious practices of Hindus, and therefore not nationalistic or beneficial to the vast majority of the people of India. An adviser to the Prime Minister recently called the judiciary the single biggest obstacle to development. The Court, perhaps, saw the textbook as an attempt to intimidate the judiciary. Some of the sentences were indeed in the form of broad-brushing social media assertions not carefully constructed with rigour. The textbook, for instance, said, “People do experience corruption at various levels of the judiciary” and went on to describe complaints and redress mechanisms. But, such critical references had been used in chapters dealing with the government or the political executive as well. The chapter on elections had a picture of currency notes apparently found in the car of a candidate. The textbook writers probably aimed to spark critical awareness, not offer bland tutorials in civic studies. But as with other textbooks, there are problematic passages. The many history chapters uncritically valorise medieval Hindu kingdoms and portray their struggle to retain power as rightful resistances to Muslim rule. Wars for plunder and territorial expansion have always been part of history, and they did not begin with Muslim invaders. Chapters on Muslim kingdoms briefly refer to Akbar's tolerance and Babur's intellectual curiosity but remain largely negative. The chapter on penury under British rule and Mughal-era wealth is not balanced. The problem is not that the textbook selectively targets the judiciary; it is that the judiciary selectively targets certain portions.

Sixteenth Finance Commission — misses and concerns

The Sixteenth Finance Commission had significant flexibility in determining its approach and methodology, as its terms of reference followed directly from constitutional provisions, unlike earlier commissions that operated under detailed central directives. This Commission, as before, addressed the two key dimensions of fiscal transfers – namely the vertical and the horizontal.

The vertical dimension

The Commission took note of the increase in the share of States in the divisible pool of central taxes from 32% to 42% by the Fourteenth Finance Commission. The Fourteenth Finance Commission had justified it on account of a discontinuation of State plan grants, amounting to only 3% of the divisible pool of central taxes at the time of transition. The subsequent reduction to 41% was due to the change in the status of Jammu and Kashmir. The Sixteenth Finance Commission noted the Centre's concern about the reduction in its fiscal space. The Centre had responded to this substantial increase in the share of states by the Fourteenth Finance Commission by, first, increasing the non-shareable cesses and surcharges, second, reducing its share in the financing of centrally sponsored schemes and third, not accepting sector-specific/State-specific grants recommended by the Fifteenth Finance Commission. In the end, however, the Sixteenth Finance Commission retained the States' share at 41%, imparting to it a kind of semi-permanence.

The Sixteenth Finance Commission makes no recommendations regarding the non-shareable cesses and surcharges which, by their very nature, should be limited and levied for finite periods. These should be earmarked for specific purposes and not merged with the Centre's general funds. Instead, Sixteenth Finance Commission recommended a ‘grand bargain’ (paragraph 7.67) between the Centre and States saying that ‘States would agree to a smaller share in the resulting larger divisible pool, with no loss of revenues to either side’ provided the Centre agreed to merge a large part of the cesses and surcharges in the regular taxes.

The Commission did not take into account its constitutional duty as enumerated in Articles 270 and 280 for objectively determining the share of States in the shareable pool of central taxes while making its observations on the cesses and surcharges. It would have been better had the



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Evaluating the federal implications of the Sixteenth Finance Commission recommendations

Commission at least pointed out to the Centre that the steep increase in cesses and surcharges was not warranted and not in the spirit of the Constitution. Further, the Commission chose to discontinue the revenue deficit grants and did not recommend any State and sector specific grants. This became a route to lower the share of States in the Centre's revenue receipts as compared to the Fifteenth Finance Commission.

The average effective transfers covering tax devolution and Finance Commission grants to the States as a percentage of the Centre's pre-transfer gross revenue receipts were 27.0%, 27.2% and 28.3%, respectively during the Finance Commission periods (11, 12, 13). This share increased sharply to 35.6% during the Fourteenth Finance Commission period. In the Fifteenth Finance Commission period, covering the years 2020-21 to 2024-25, this share came down marginally to 34.4%, still considerably higher than those of the Eleventh and Thirteenth Finance Commission periods. This steep increase in resources transferred as a proportion of gross revenue receipts of the Centre should not be overlooked.

Looking at the first year of the Sixteenth Finance Commission's award period, 2026-27, this ratio is 32.7% as per the Centre's budget estimates. The Sixteenth Finance Commission's projections for later years may prove to be overestimates since the 2026-27 nominal GDP growth, assumed at 11%, is higher than the Budget estimate of 10%. The Commission also did not factor in the revenue reducing effect of the major Goods and Services Tax (GST) reforms undertaken in September 2025, while the Commission was still in session.

Horizontal dimension

The Sixteenth Finance Commission introduced a new criterion of contribution to reflect an efficiency consideration. But it measured it through the share of a State's Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) in an all-State GSDP.

There is a need, however, to differentiate the efficiency of the production system from that of the fiscal system. In the production system, the inter-State distribution of GSDP depends on many factors which includes the inter-State movement of financial and human resources. It largely depends on market forces which tend to lead to a concentration of productive capital stock in a limited number of States. Human resources also move from less developed to the more developed States.

Skill India as herculean challenges, Galgotian blunders

Once-in-a-lifetime opportunity requires a herculean effort. India's demographic dividend, that ends by 2040, is one such opportunity. Several European Union countries and China have successfully financed skill systems. In these countries, approximately 50% of secondary-level students are enrolled in vocational education streams. In India that share is 1.3%, reflective of an educational system that neglected school education till 1990, and vocational education till 2006.

However, in 2020, India's National Education Policy (NEP) said: “By 2025, 50% learners will be exposed to vocational education.” “Exposed” still reveals an attitudinal problem among policy designers. Vocational education in most countries is around 2% of the education budget. For China and Germany it is 11%. India has no data that is publicly available due to fragmented training schemes in Ministries. India's strategy rests on Budget announcements which falter year-on-year. A scheme that was celebrated last year is forgotten the next year. Consider the internship scheme announced in Budget FY 2026: only 5% of the allocated funds were spent and its design proved ineffective.

CAG reports, issues raised

The herculean task of making India “the skill capital of the world” is inconsistent with “Galgotian” blunders. Issues of financing skills are crucial. The Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) in 2025 audited the flagship Skill India scheme, Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana (PMKVY)-2015-22. Ten years ago, it had similarly looked at compliance and oversight issues of skill institutions.

Both reports raise issues of financial impropriety. In 2015, the CAG dealt with financial reporting delays and unclear accountability of disbursed funds. In 2025, the report mentions that 94.5% of bank accounts were invalid and approximately 41% of trainees in short-term training achieved placement.

How have we evolved from 2015 through 2025? When the short-term skill ecosystem was started, the vision was to create a vibrant public-private market for skills. Over the past decade, however, the focus on quantity through short-term training

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A. Singh

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Reforming skill financing is crucial to harness India's demographic dividend

has yielded limited results. Since the CAG's direct concern is fund use, we list three ideas for it.

Imagine a scenario where no operational funding was provided by the PMKVY. What if the amount upward of ₹10,000 crore spent annually was extended as skill loans to students? This would have led to more choices for students, improved the quality of institutions as they competed for enrolment, and promoted demand-driven skill development, benefiting students as they are from economically weaker backgrounds. A model similar to that for educational loans could have been followed. The worst case would be non-performing assets, which we have ways to handle. It is not too late. We can do so now and use skill loans better. There is already a policy framework in place. Priority needs to shift: part of PMKVY funding could be through skill loans. Of course, design work is needed to roll this out, but it is doable. It needs a product-market that has banks and non-banking financial companies on board. It is worth questioning why the National Skill Development Corporation began as a non-banking finance company, later became a funder for training partners, and now primarily implements government schemes.

Using skill vouchers

Use of skill vouchers is another trainee-based skills financing idea, more so for distribution of public funds. It allows flexibility for policymakers and a choice for students. There is no better way to implement the NEP priority of lifelong learning.

Since vouchers follow the trainee rather than the institution, it incentivises delivery and outcomes. It creates a competitive market. Vouchers can also be good tools to provide upskilling for Artificial Intelligence (AI)-led transition, providing targeted skills in AI, digital and green skills. They can be used for needed segments such as enhancing women workforce participation or provide foreign language learning for global labour markets.

Purchasing power in the hands of learners will drive quality and accountability and be a driver of a demand-based skills market. Singapore and Croatia have implemented them well. It will also

This change involved using GSDP in two opposite ways. In the income distance formula, the lower the per-capita GSDP of a State, the higher the per-capita share of that State. In the contribution criterion, the higher the per-capita GSDP of a State, the higher is its share. However, the Commission did not finally use the GSDP. Instead, it used its square root. This was meant to reduce the excessive effects of using GSDP to reflect contribution on some States.

In the devolution formula, the weights of some of the other criteria have also been changed. These are purely judgemental. Dropping the tax effort/fiscal discipline criterion, which was a fiscal efficiency criterion is not consistent with the Commission's own narrative.

Losses and gains

Consequently, the main States that have lost on account of the Sixteenth Finance Commission devolution scheme as compared to the Fifteenth Finance Commission are Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, Bihar, Odisha, Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan. The other group of losing States are Arunachal Pradesh, Meghalaya, Manipur, Nagaland, Tripura, Sikkim, and Goa (the north-east or extremely small States). The gain by other richer States has not been uniform.

Ideally, the losses of some States could have been mitigated through normatively determined revenue gap grants. Devolution is not enough to capture the finer details of cost and need differentials of India's highly differentiated States. Further, if a Finance Commission changes the tax devolution formulae, then the consequential loss of some of the States could be neutralised by the revenue gap grants.

In fact, Article 275 provides an important mode of fiscal transfers for the consideration of State-specific ‘needs’. It should not be confused with revenue deficits. Needs can be estimated in order to equalise standards of critical services such as health and education.

This would have facilitated accommodating the performance argument of the richer States while still promoting the equalisation objective. Even if there are difficulties in estimating revenue gap grants since it involves normative assessment of States' needs and resources, the Sixteenth Finance Commission need not have taken the shortcut of dropping these altogether. While ad hoc State-specific grants are not appropriate, equalisation grants still have a place.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Iran attacked

The U.S.-Israel assault on Iran is best understood as an economic war, not merely a security operation. The architecture goes back to Richard Nixon's petrodollar deal of 1973 — oil priced in dollars, OPEC surpluses recycled into US Treasuries. The 1979 Iranian Revolution was intolerable precisely because it shattered this arrangement,

creating the first major oil state outside dollar subservience. Since then, the pattern is consistent — Iraq in 2003, Libya in 2011, Iran today — each had challenged dollar dominance. U.S. President Donald Trump is defending the same financial order, whatever his rhetoric. Until we debate this economic dimension honestly, we will keep misreading these

conflicts entirely.
Gopalaswamy J.,
Chennai

The U.S. has this tendency to call North Korea, Iran and others as rogue states because they challenge America's hegemonic ways. In fact, rogue nations are not those that intend to or possess nuclear weapons, but those which attack others on flimsy or

unfounded grounds. At a time when the Russian war in Ukraine is on, the strikes on Iran will prove catastrophic for security in West Asia. It is the U.S. that always

indulges in aggressive sabre-rattling and unprovoked military interventions across the world.
Prabhu Raj R.,
Bengaluru

The killing of Iran's Ali Khamenei is a blatant violation by the U.S. The U.S. under Mr. Trump is becoming a rogue country. With the UN long valueless, the world is becoming a dangerous place.

V. Ganapathy Subramanian,
Nagercoil, Tamil Nadu

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the full postal address.

How UGC rules prioritise quick justice

The University Grants Commission's (UGC) 2026 regulation on the promotion of equity in higher education has triggered protests by a section of general category students and a *Sadhu sangathan* (organisation of ascetics). The matter finally reached the Supreme Court which has put the implementation on hold for its complete vagueness. Opposition to the regulation stems from the apprehension that marginalised sections, taking advantage of the vagueness in the new rules, might misuse the regulation to victimise upper castes. This reflects deep distrust and insecurity which is fuelled by fears that measures aimed at providing justice to one section of the population could turn out to be unjust for others.

Caution against speedy justice
This regulation is necessitated by an undeniable reality. Caste, gender and religion-based discrimination in higher educational institutions are neither sporadic nor episodic, and instances of the same have lately been rising. Grievance redress mechanisms have been notoriously slow, often discretionary, and at times only symbolic, leaving students from marginalised communities to suffer the consequences in silence. Even the most ardent opponents of this new regulation cannot, therefore, deny the necessity of such an intervention. Their consternation arises from the apprehension that the overemphasis on speed to meaningfully deliver justice in institutions shaped by layered hierarchies, informal power, and uneven capacities might be misplaced, as speed and justice share a very complicated relationship. Too slow, and it loses meaning; too fast, it risks losing judgment altogether. The 2026 regulations insist on swift redress, strict accountability, and institutional consequences for silence or inaction. Complaints



Furqan Qamar
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Sameer Ahmad Khan
is a research scholar at Jamia Millia Islamia

Students from rural areas and linguistic minorities often struggle to translate everyday discrimination into administratively legible complaints

must be acknowledged immediately, committees convened swiftly, and inquiries concluded within rigid timelines. This design rests on a powerful assumption – that speed and fairness naturally reinforce one another. Yet, justice systems across the world suggest otherwise. When urgency is institutionalised without explicit safeguards, decisiveness begins to substitute for deliberation. Quick timelines and central monitoring without clear procedural standards create fear. Institutions worry about regulatory penalties as well as reputational damage from complaints processed rapidly and unfairly. The new regulation assumes that the time taken in due diligence and completing procedural formalities is akin to institutional inertia. It seeks to ensure rapid enforcement by threatening higher educational institutions with dire consequences. They could be de-recognised and lose the power to award degrees. However, whether this shift commands legitimacy, will depend not on intent alone, but on the architecture of enforcement.

Vague process
The experience of U.S. universities during the 2010s is instructive. Faced with the pressure to act swiftly on campus misconduct, institutions prioritised speed, only to encounter sustained judicial pushback over vague evidentiary standards, unclear rights of response, and reputational harm inflicted before findings were even established. The backlash did not arise because protection was unnecessary, but because the process was thin. Clearly, justice that moves quickly but unclearly destroys trust. That risk is magnified by how the UGC regulations distribute authority. They do not specify offences or penalties. Investigation is delegated to internal equity committees, and punishment is imposed through existing institutional services or

disciplinary rules. Faced with the threat of de-recognition or funding withdrawal, universities are encouraged to prioritise visible action over careful adjudication, which produces fear. And fear, in regulatory environments, rarely fosters justice.

Rewarding privilege
At this point, legal design collides with social reality. The ability to document harm, articulate it in institutional language, and navigate committees remains unevenly distributed. Students from rural areas, and linguistic minorities often struggle to translate everyday discrimination into administratively legible complaints. Meanwhile, those with greater cultural and institutional exposure, sometimes from dominant sub-castes within protected categories, are better positioned to mobilise the system. The result is a quiet paradox. A regime designed to amplify marginal voices ends up privileging the most institutionally fluent among them. These pressures inevitably spill into classrooms. When academic judgment is subjected to regulatory scrutiny without procedural clarity, risk aversion becomes the most logical course. Faculty respond by diluting feedback, avoiding difficult conversations, and sanitising evaluation. And over time, institutions learn ways to bypass the complexities. Committees multiply, documentation thickens, and compliance becomes performative. Scholars describe this as compliance theatre, a phenomenon where organisations learn to demonstrate reform without addressing underlying hierarchies. Justice in universities must not be a race to the first response. It should be a long and difficult conversation. One that demands urgency, yes, but also precision, patience, and the humility to revise. Without that balance, equity will quietly and persistently slip out of the room.

How one seat will test the MVA's unity

MVAs fragile alliance lies in the balance in the upcoming Rajya Sabha elections

STATE OF PLAY

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
vinaya.deshpande@thehindu.co.in

On February 26, the Election Commission (EC) issued a notification for the election to 37 Rajya Sabha seats in 10 States. Of them, seven seats are from Maharashtra. Among those who will complete their tenures on April 2 this year are leaders like Nationalist Congress Party-SP (NCP-SP) president Sharad Pawar and Union Minister Ramdas Athawale. As political parties across alliances in Maharashtra try to gain the most at the negotiating table, the election to one Rajya Sabha seat is likely to test the fragile unity of the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA), a regional alliance of the INDIA bloc. The major questions this election will raise for the MVA are whether the Congress will be willing to compromise at a time when both the Rajya Sabha elections and Legislative Council elections are to take place in Maharashtra; whether Uddhav Thackeray will forsake his party's claim to the sole Rajya Sabha seat when his is the biggest party in the State's Opposition; and what Sharad Pawar will decide. Negotiations are ongoing within the Mahayuti as well. While the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) wants four seats, the NCP has declared Parth Pawar's (Ajit Pawar's son) name. Eknath Shinde is keen to get two seats.

The MVA tussle
The battle within the MVA throws light on the aspirations of each of the three parties. It is defined by an undeniable shadow of distrust towards the NCP-SP, after talks of a merger with Ajit Pawar's NCP



were revealed. In Maharashtra, the NCP (earlier led by Ajit Pawar and now by his wife Sunetra Pawar) is in power with the BJP as part of the Mahayuti alliance. The NCP-SP (led by Sharad Pawar), on the other hand, is a part of the Opposition MVA, with Congress and Shiv Sena Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray (UBT). While some leaders said that the death of Ajit Pawar had effectively halted the possibility of a merger, others questioned whether the Rajya Sabha seat will remain with the INDIA bloc in the future, if the NCP-SP decides to go ahead with the merger. "Even if Sharad Pawar himself may choose to stay with the MVA, what if his party goes ahead with the merger?" asked a leader. Some even raised concerns about Sharad Pawar's health. He is currently recovering at a hospital in Mumbai. The NCP-SP counts on the heft of a national leader like Sharad Pawar to propose that his candidature alone can lead to an unopposed Rajya Sabha victory in the State. Meanwhile, the Shiv Sena UBT is keen to take this Rajya Sabha seat for itself. It believes that since it is the largest party in the alliance, and had left its stake in 2019 to support Fauziah Khan (NCP-SP), it should be supported for this bid. While five leaders are in the fray, the preference seems to be for Priyanka Chaturvedi, whose term expires next month. "We have been a loyal

partner in the INDIA bloc. We have taken up several national issues including the Adani-sation of Mumbai. Our presence in Rajya Sabha is crucial," a Sena leader said. The Congress, on the other hand, feels the need to increase its presence in the Rajya Sabha to play an effective role as the national Opposition party. "For us, each seat in the Parliament matters to strengthen Mallikarjun Kharge ji," a Congress leader said. The BJP has refrained from issuing any statement on the differences within the MVA so far. But the possibility of more candidates being in the fray will only nix the chances of unopposed elections, and will lead to complex number crunching in an open ballot election.

A game of numbers
The number game in Maharashtra is quite clear. Rajya Sabha members are voted in by the MLAs of the State. In a House of 288, the actual strength today is 286. The election quota for the Rajya Sabha election in Maharashtra is 36. In the ruling Mahayuti, the BJP has 131 MLAs, Shiv Sena (Eknath Shinde) has 57 MLAs, and NCP has 40. Along with smaller allies, the Mahayuti strength is 234. Effectively, it can easily elect six of the seven Rajya Sabha members. It will have a handful of excess votes too. On the Opposition side, the MVA can also elect one candidate on the basis of its cumulative strength if it sticks together. The Shiv Sena UBT has 20 MLAs, the Congress has 16 and the NCP-SP has 10. Along with the smaller allies, its total strength is 52. The final decision will now hinge on talks between the top three leaders of the MVA. The Opposition will be able to keep uncertainty at bay only if it can achieve consensus.

U.P. receives over 84% of all out-of-State MPLADS funds

Only 21 MPs, two of them from the Lok Sabha, accounted for all of the out-of-usual-area spending

DATA POINT

Nitika Francis
Vignesh Radhakrishnan

Twenty-one MPs recommended works outside the State or constituency they were elected from or are associated with, using their Members of Parliament Local Area Development Scheme (MPLADS) funds, an analysis by *The Hindu* has found. And of the more than ₹18 crore spent on works which were completed based on these recommendations, the vast majority – 84% – went to districts in Uttar Pradesh. Of the 530 MPs for whom "completed works" data is available, these 21 MPs account for all of the out-of-usual-area spending. All other MPs used their allocated funds in the districts or States they represent or are associated with. The analysis by *The Hindu* covered around 21,000 works completed between 2023 and 2026. The data were sourced from the Empowered Indian MPLADS dashboard and cross-verified with the mplads.gov.in website. It was collected on February 23, 2026. An elected Lok Sabha MP can generally recommend works in the district(s) their constituency encompasses. An elected Rajya Sabha MP can recommend works only within the State they are elected from, while nominated MPs can recommend works anywhere in the country. There are also limited exceptions: MPs can recommend up to ₹50 lakh in a financial year outside their usual region (raised from ₹25 lakh after April 2023) and can also contribute up to ₹1 crore per annum for rehabilitation and reconstruction in areas affected by natural "calamities of severe nature", as declared by the Government of India, subject to additional scrutiny.

Exhaustive list
Of the 21 MPs, only two are from the Lok Sabha. Mala Rajya Laxmi



In the works: Reconstruction of a road begins near NH-709B, Sisana village, in Baghpat, Uttar Pradesh on February 4. ANI

Shah of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), the Lok Sabha MP from Uttarakhand's Tehri Garhwal, spent ₹49,96,274 on footpaths and pedestrian ways built in two villages of Agra district. This amount is about 57% of her total spending of ₹87.4 lakh on all completed works. In other words, more than half of her spending on completed works went to Uttar Pradesh, with the rest spent in the Dehradun district, where parts of the Tehri Garhwal Lok Sabha constituency lie. When *The Hindu* reached out to her, she declined to comment. Another Lok Sabha MP, Kirti Vardhan Singh from Uttar Pradesh, spent ₹10 lakh on a protective structure in Nagaland. Sadanand Mhalu Shet Tanavade, the sitting Rajya Sabha MP of the BJP from Goa, spent ₹48.6 lakh on street light poles installed in 20 locations across the Shahjahanpur district of Uttar Pradesh. The amount is about 27% of his total spending on all completed works. Chunnilal Garasiya, the sitting Rajya Sabha MP of the BJP from Rajasthan, spent ₹98 lakh on LED lights installed in two districts of Uttar Pradesh, about 80% of his total spending on all completed works. He said he did not remember the specific areas for which he had recommended the works from the MPLADS funds. "I don't exact-

ly remember the sectors or areas for which I have made recommendations. These things are handled by my private secretary. I have not even completed two years in office," Mr. Garasiya told *The Hindu* over phone. Mr. Garasiya was elected to the Rajya Sabha from Rajasthan in April 2024. Sitting Rajya Sabha MP of the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha from Jharkhand, Sarfraz Ahmad, spent ₹92.03 lakh on installing LED lights and building roads in the Agra and Pilibhit districts. This is one of the very few instances of such "out-of-State" funding wherein the involved MP is from a regional party and has contributed such a substantial amount to a State where said party has no footing. "I have followed the rules of the Rajya Sabha and as a member I am entitled to recommend a certain percentage of the MPLADS funds to other States as well. I have recommended the funds to Jharkhand also," Mr. Ahmad told *The Hindu* over phone. Asked about any other specific reason to recommend funds out of his usual area, Mr. Ahmed said, "The way I have my people in Jharkhand, in the similar way I have my people in Uttar Pradesh as well." Other sitting Rajya Sabha MPs who sent money to works in Uttar Pradesh include BJP's Rajendra

Gehlot and Congress's Pramod Tiwari, both from Rajasthan; BJP's Satish Chandra Dubey from Bihar; and Congress' K.T.S. Tulsi and Phulo Devi Netam from Chhattisgarh. Together, they sent around ₹75 lakh to various projects in Uttar Pradesh. Of the ₹18 crore out-of-usual-area funds, about 6% went to Bihar, and sitting BJP Rajya Sabha MP Dhananjay Bhimrao Mahadik from Maharashtra accounts for most of it. He spent close to ₹1 crore on works in Bihar, spread across two financial years. **The established norm** While nominated Rajya Sabha MPs are allowed to use their MPLADS funds anywhere in the country, few actually do so beyond the States they're associated with. Most concentrate spending in the States where they built their careers – the very achievements that led to their nomination. For instance, ace track and field athlete P.T. Usha, who was nominated to the Rajya Sabha, has spent all of her MPLADS funds thus far on roads and playgrounds and to purchase school buses across Kerala. Similarly, Dharmas-thala's Veerendra Hegdega spent all his funds till now in Karnataka. **The lion's share** Gulam Ali Khatana is a notable ex-

ception. He was born and educated in Jammu & Kashmir and has his permanent residence in the Union Territory. He is identified as a BJP member in his Rajya Sabha profile and has served as a spokesperson of the party's J&K unit. At the time of appointment, he was the lone member representing the State in the Upper House. Of the 20 questions he has raised in the Rajya Sabha, 16 relate specifically to matters in J&K, including questions on welfare funds for tribal communities and their forest rights. Mr. Khatana is a member of the Scheduled Tribe (Gurjar/Gujjar) community, according to his Rajya Sabha profile. Yet he spent nearly ₹12 crore of his MPLADS funds to install LED lights in various districts of Uttar Pradesh, accounting for over 95% of his total MPLADS expense. Of the 21 MPs analysed for mismatched funds, Mr. Khatana accounts for the largest share. Uttar Pradesh already receives a large share of MPLADS funds because it sends the most MPs to Parliament. Of the 20,858 works completed between 2023 and 2026, 26% were in Uttar Pradesh. Around a fifth of the utilised funds also went to the State. Uttar Pradesh utilises more than twice as much MPLADS funds as the second-ranked Tamil Nadu, with the latter accounting for around 9%. Against this background, the mismatch is more pronounced: over 84% of the out-of-usual-area funds were directed to Uttar Pradesh. In several instances, the funds came from MPs elected from or associated with States with lower per capita incomes and a smaller share of MPLADS funds. J&K, with which Mr. Khatana is so strongly associated, received only 0.6% of the MPLADS utilised funds and accounted for only about 1% of completed works. *With inputs from Mohammed Iqbal, Ishita Mishra, Amit Bhelari, who are reporters at The Hindu, and Suman Raj L., Shriram N., and Nivedha M. who interned with the Data Team.*

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO MARCH 2, 1976

Arafat suggests UN buffer zone in Israeli-held area

Washington, Feb. 29: Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO) leader Mr. Yasser Arafat has proposed the creation of United Nations buffer zone in Israeli occupied Arab territory as a step to a West Asian peace conference and recognition of Israel's right to exist. The *Washington Post* newspaper reported today. It said he put the proposal to Democratic Senator, Mr. Adlai Stevenson during the Senator's recent tour of Egypt, Saudi Arabia, Lebanon, Syria, Iraq, Iran and Israel. According to the proposal, the U.N. would take over the occupied areas except for parts of the Gaza strip and the west bank of Jordan adjoining Israel. These adjoining parts will be administered jointly by Israel and the U.N. the newspaper said. The newspaper said Mr. Arafat indicated to Senator Stevenson that if Israel made that first move it could break the deadlock that has held up resumption of West Asian peace talks in Geneva. The *Post* said that according to Senator Stevenson, who met the PLO leader in Beirut and took his proposal to the Israeli and U.S. Governments, the Israelis showed little interest in the suggestion. – Reuter

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO MARCH 2, 1926

Fastest car in the world

The London correspondent of "The Englishman" cables under date Feb. 6 – What is expected to prove the world's fastest motor car was to-day surrounded by a dozen experts and detectives in a closely guarded shed in the Sunbeam works at Wolverhampton. I was among the few privileged persons who inspected the car, which has been shrouded in secrecy during the last eighteen months. Major Segrave, who will drive the car on the Southport sands probably to-morrow; hopes to beat the world record of 150.269 miles an hour secured on the Pendine sands in South Wales in July last year. The car has twelve cylinders and is only 33 horse-power according to Treasury rating but it is claimed that it can develop 300 horse-power at 6,000 revolutions. France, Italy and the United States are all making hectic preparations to produce cars which will attempt to beat the mile and kilometre records now held by Britain.

CBSE defers exams in West Asia region amid tensions

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) on Sunday postponed the Class 10 and 12 Board exams scheduled for March 2 in the West Asia region amid the Iran-Israel conflict, officials said.

“Due to current situation in parts of Middle East – Bahrain, Iran, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and UAE, the board has decided to postpone class 10, 12 exams on March 2,” said CBSE Examination Controller Sanyam Bhardwaj.

“The new dates will be announced later,” Mr. Bhardwaj added.

“The Board will review the situation on March 3 and take appropriate decisions with regard to examination scheduled from March 5 onwards,” the CBSE Examination Controller further said.

Indians among injured in Iranian strikes: UAE

Conflict between U.S.-Israel alliance and Iran sends shock waves across West Asia; oil tanker with Indians among crew hit off Oman coast; eight Indians stuck in Karachi airport after aircraft diversion over the conflict; MEA urges foreign nationals who could not leave India to contact their nearest FRRO for visa extension and stay regularisation

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Several Indians were among those who have been injured in the missile and drone attacks by Iran in West Asia, authorities in the UAE and Oman said on Sunday. The announcement came as the conflict between U.S.-Israel alliance and the Islamic Republic entered its second day even as Indian missions heightened activities to address concerns of citizens scattered across West Asia.

Three were killed in drone attacks and 58, including Indians, were injured in the UAE, the Defence Ministry of the Gulf country said. Iran launched 541 drones at Abu Dhabi and Dubai and nearly 506 of these were destroyed by the UAE forces, the Ministry said. “Three deaths of Pakistani,

Nepalese, and Bangladeshi nationalities, and 58 cases of minor injuries of Emirati, Egyptian, Ethiopian, Filipino, Pakistani, Iranian, Indian, Bangladeshi, Sri Lankan, Azerbaijani, Yemeni, Ugandan, Eritrean, Lebanese, and Afghan nationalities.” A total of 165 ballistic missiles launched by Iran were detected since the beginning of the conflict and 152 of them were destroyed, it said.

An oil tanker with 20 crew members, 15 among them Indians, was targeted off the Oman coast, the Maritime Security Centre of Oman said. The tanker *Skylight*, under the flag of the Republic of Palau, was struck five nautical miles north of the Khasab port in the Musandam Governorate and the crew were evacuated, it said, adding that “preliminary information also indicates varying injuries among four mem-



Embassy outreach: Indian embassy officials interact with nationals stranded in Kuwait amid temporary airspace shutdown. PTI

bers of the ship's crew who have been transferred to receive necessary medical treatment”.

Stranded passengers
The ripple effect of the conflict is being felt across India with flight cancellations and uncertainties leaving people stranded at multiple locations.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on Sunday issued an order urging all fo-

reign nationals who failed to leave India because of the conflict to reach out to their nearest Foreigners Regional Registration Office (FRRO) for extension of visa and regularisation of stay.

A total of 84 students and 4 faculty members of Indira University's School of Business, Pune, were stuck in Dubai after temporary closure of UAE airspace. The team had tra-

Protests in Kashmir over Khamenei killing, schools closed for two days

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Spontaneous and widespread street protests erupted across Kashmir, including the capital Srinagar and in Ladakh on Sunday over the killing of Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Khamenei in an Israel-U.S. attack.

Security was stepped up across the valley in response to the demonstrations. J&K Director-General of Police (DGP) Nalin Prabhat patrolled the streets of Srinagar to monitor the situation, while authorities warned residents against “misusing social media”. Fearing more protests, the J&K government ordered the closure of all educational institutions in Kashmir for the next two days.



People gather outside the UNMOGIP office in Srinagar during a protest, chanting slogans critical of the U.S. and Israel. IMRAN NISSAR

mostly from the Shia sect, poured onto the streets in Srinagar, Budgam, Baramulla and Bandipora districts. Significant protests were also reported in Kargil and Leh districts of Ladakh.

The largest rally took place at Ghanta Ghar (Clock Tower) in Srinagar where demonstrators offered congregational prayers and marched to the office of the United Nations Military Observer Group in India and Pakistan (UNMOGIP) to register their protest. Beating their chests and mourning, protesters draped the clock tower with images of the slain leader and raised anti-U.S. and anti-Israel slogans.

“The death of a martyr

infuses life into the nation's cause,” said a protester.

Waheed Ur Rehman Parra of the Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) joined the protests at Lal Chowk. Top Shia clerics in Kashmir, including Aga Syed Ruhullah, Imran Ansari, Masroor Abbas and Aga Syed Muntazir Mehdi, expressed sorrow over the killing.

“There will be 40 days of official mourning across the region. Black flags will be hoisted at all mosques, imambargahs, and religious institutions across the Valley,” said Shia cleric Aga Syed Hassan Al-Moosavi Al-Safavi, president of Anjuman-e-Sharie Shian.

The Muttahida Majlis-e-Ulama, an amalgam of Islamic organisations head-

ed by Mirwaiz Umar Farooq, called for a shutdown on Monday. “I am deeply saddened and outraged at the brutal killing. It has shaken the Muslim world. This is a moment for the Muslim Ummah to rise above divisions, stand united, and register our protest and solidarity against this killing and the continued aggression in the region,” the Mirwaiz said.

Former J&K Chief Minister and PDP president Mehbooba Mufti described the killing as “a deeply tragic and shameful point in history”. She criticised Israel and the U.S. for celebrating the act and condemned Muslim countries that “chose convenience over conscience.” “Israel and the U.S. are boasting about the killing. What's more disgraceful and shocking is the explicit and implicit support given by Muslim countries who chose convenience and expedience over conscience,” Mr. Mufti said.

“History will stand as testament to who fought for justice and who helped the oppressors. Prayers with the people of Iran. May Allah grant them strength & victory over forces of tyranny and injustice,” she said.

Centre flags risk of violence after U.S.-Israel strikes on Iran

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The Union Home Ministry has cautioned States against “possible violence” and “sporadic protests” in India in the wake of a joint military operations by the U.S. and Israel against Iran, a senior government official told *The Hindu*.

Thousands of people took to the streets across the country in protest against the killing of Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. Demonstrations were held in Uttar Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh, Karnataka, and Delhi, among others, by Shia groups.

In a communication sent to the Chief Secretaries and Directors-General of Police on Saturday, the Ministry asked the States to keep a watch on protests and demonstrations by “affiliates of both pro- and anti-Iranian regime” at the embassies and consulate offices of Iran, the U.S., and Israel, the official said.

It also asked the States to identify “pro-Iran radical preachers giving inflammatory sermons and provoking violent actions”.

The States have been asked to monitor the social media activities of “pro-Iran extremists and the global terrorist groups



People hold portraits of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei during a protest in Hyderabad on Sunday. PTI

(GTG) handles”, and enhance the watch on “pro-Iran student organisations and socio-political organisations”.

Likely targets
According to the Ministry, the likely targets of the Shia militia groups, as well as the global terror groups such as the Islamic State and Al Qaeda, may include the U.S. and Israeli embassies and consulates in India and their staff, delegations, business persons, resorts, business establishments, tourist sites frequented by westerners, synagogues, Chhabad Houses, kosher shops, and Jewish community centres.

The Ministry asked the States to sensitise security personnel regarding the threat perception, and the need to augment security

arrangements, particularly in and around the embassies and consulates, and also tourist locations frequented by Israeli, American, and Iranian visitors.

It suggested CCTV coverage and checking of locations for the presence of improvised explosives devices and explosive substances.

“It is also requested to take measures, including security arrangements at the sites mentioned above and other vulnerable locations to prevent any untoward incident and to maintain law and order, peace, and public tranquility. A watch may also be kept on social media to curb the spread of misinformation and requisite action may be taken in this regard,” the Ministry said.

Parties say killing of Khamenei is unlawful

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The killing of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in joint U.S.-Israel strikes was condemned by several Opposition parties on Sunday.

AIMIM president Asaduddin Owaisi termed the killing an “immoral and unlawful act”, and expressed the hope that the Centre would play a role in stopping the war.

CPI leader D. Raja said that the U.S.-Israel “nexus represents evil in its most naked form”. “To now assassinate a sitting head of state is to strip the so-called rules-based order of its last pretence. Sovereignty clearly applies only to those aligned with Washington,” Mr. Raja said on X.

Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut slammed the Centre for its stand following the U.S.-Israeli attack on India's “friend” Iran. He said that Iran becoming weak is also dangerous for India because if the U.S. and Israel control the West Asian country, their steps will move towards India.

RJD MP Manoj Jha said: “The U.S.-Israel-Iran war is very shameful, and it is not going to stop; the UN has lost its meaning.”

‘Attack on Iran signals revival of coercive unilateralism’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Sunday condemned the “targeted assassination” of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, Supreme Leader of the Islamic Republic of Iran, without a formal declaration of war by the U.S. and Israel.

“The targeted use of force to destabilise the leadership and governing structures of a sovereign state – whether in Iran or earlier in Venezuela – signals a disturbing revival of regime-change doctrines and coercive unilateralism,” Mr. Kharge said.

“A targeted killing of a sitting head of state strikes at the heart of these international rules,” he further said.

Centre's response to Iran war is betrayal of India's values, principles, interests: Congress

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

In a sustained attack on the foreign policy of the Union government led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the Congress on Sunday alleged that the Centre's response to the war inflicted on Iran amounted to a betrayal of India's “values, principles, concerns and interests”.

The country, the party said, is paying a heavy price for both the “substance and style” of Mr. Modi's foreign policy.

Despite “grandstanding” by the Prime Minister's supporters, India's foreign policy under the “self-styled Vishwaguru” stood “brutally exposed”, Congress general secretary



continues his romance with Pakistan, applauding again and again the very man whose inflammatory remarks provided the backdrop to the terror attacks in Pahalgam on April 22, 2025,” Mr. Ramesh said.

President Trump had claimed “a hundred times” that he had secured the cessation of Operation Sindoor by threatening increased tariffs on Indian exports.

The eventual U.S.-India trade deal, Mr. Ramesh said, had been concluded “at Mr. Modi's request”, and was now seen as one-sided, with India agreeing to liberalise imports, especially in agricultural commodities, without equivalent commitments from the U.S.



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(EOI No. EOI/010/CO/2025-26 dated March 02nd, 2026)
BRBNMPL invites Global Expression Of Interest (EOI) from eligible, bonafide and resourceful bidders “to set-up a plant for manufacturing colour shift film, Colour Shift Pigment & other products at BRBNMPL, Mysuru, India”

Filled in response with details are to be submitted in physical mode to the Chief General Manager, Bharatiya Reserve Bank Note Mudran Private Limited, Corporate Office, No. 3 & 4, 1st Stage, 1st Phase, BTM Layout, Bannerghatta Road, Bengaluru – 560 029, India by **14:30 hrs. IST on or before April 30th, 2026**. The submitted bids shall be opened at **15:00 hrs. IST on April 30th, 2026**.

For EOI documents, eligibility criteria and other details, please visit our website www.brbtnmpl.co.in. All further amendments/corrigendum if any, shall be notified only on the Company website as above. Interested bidders are requested to visit our website periodically to know changes / amendments, if any.



COCHIN INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT LIMITED
CIAL/COMM/SSW/15/2025-26/01 02/03/2026

TENDER NOTICE

Online item rate E-Tenders are invited from reputed agencies for the work mentioned below at Cochin International Airport.

Sl. No.	Name of Work	Tender Document Fee	EMD	Completion Period
1	Appointment of Consultant for Upgradation of Integrated Airport Management System at Cochin International Airport	Rs. 10,000/- + GST	Rs. 10,00,000/-	24 months

Interested firms may register themselves on the online E-Tendering portal <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> and then download the Tender documents. For eligibility criteria and other details, visit our website: www.cial.aero. For further updates on this tender, please visit <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in>

Sd/- Managing Director

PUNJAB STATE GRAINS PROCUREMENT CORPORATION LIMITED (PUNGRAIN)
ANAAJ BHAWAN, SECTOR 39-C, CHANDIGARH

Notice Inviting Tender

Bids are invited from bidders for the purchase of 18000 HDPE Monofilament Nets (Meshnets) for storage of wheat during RMS 2026-27 on behalf of all State Procuring Agencies (Pungrain, PSWC, Punsup and Markfed) in the State of Punjab.

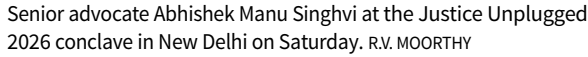
For details log onto: <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in> or <http://foodsuppb.gov.in>

Bid Submission Start Date and Time: 10:00 AM on 02.03.2026
Bid Submission Last Date and Time: Till 11:00 AM on 12.03.2026.
Date and time of Opening Technical Bid: 12:00 Noon on 12.03.2026.
Pre-bid Conference: On 05.03.2026 at 11:00 AM in the Committee room, Anaj Bhawan, Sector 39-C, Chandigarh.

Note: Any corrigendum(s)/addendum(s) to the e-tender shall be published on the above websites only.

1027/12/2025-26/8933 **Managing Director, PUNGRAIN**

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



in association with **THE HINDU**

Use AI like a co-pilot, not as autopilot: VIT vice-president

G.V. Selvam says social media aids in developing contacts, which can be converted into clients for lawyers. R.V. MOORTHY

"It connects the world with you. It develops contacts. These contacts can be converted into clients for a lawyer," he said.

"The world today faces the dual challenge of ensuring environmental conservation while progressing amid the climate change crisis. Maharashtra, too, is addressing climate change while continuing on its path of development. There are numerous opportunities for Canada to invest in Maharashtra," Mr. Fadnavis said.

SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle

A	I	N	C	A	R	C	E	R	A	T	E		
B	I	D	E	T	S	A	T	E	L	L	I	T	E
A	I	T	U	O	E	D	N						
T	R	A	V	E	L	L	I	N	G	V	E	N	T
E	A	R	R	T	I								
S	I	N	A	L	E	S	A	L	E	S	M	E	N
E	E	N											
E	M	I	S	T	R	O	N						
L	I	G											
P	O	L	I	C	E								
P	O	L	I	C	E								
O	B	E	R	D	N	E	A	D	P	N			
W	H	O	L	E	S	A	N	G	U	L	P	S	
S	U	R	N	D	V	E	E	R					
S													
R	I	G	H	T	H	A	N	D	E	R			

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

5	1	4	7	9	6	3	8	2
8	6	3	2	1	5	4	9	7
7	9	2	4	8	3	1	5	6
4	3	1	5	6	9	7	2	8
6	5	7	8	4	2	9	1	3
9	2	8	3	7	1	6	4	5
2	7	5	9	3	4	8	6	1
3	4	6	1	5	8	2	7	9
1	8	9	6	2	7	5	3	4

FAITH

Seek moksha

Different people have different desires, and there are devatas who can grant them their wishes, said Valayapet Ramachariar in a discourse. Those who want their *indriyas* to function well propitiate Indra. Those who want wealth pray to Maya Devi, says *Srimad Bhagavatam*. While some people interpret this as a reference to Durga Devi, it can be taken as a reference to Mahalakshmi. There is a form of Lakshmi known as *adhikararchai*. When there is a separate shrine for Lakshmi in a temple, then we can pray to the Goddess enshrined there for wealth and worldly pleasures. One who wants grains in plenty should pray to Aditi. One prays to Varuna for riches. For good marital relations, one should pray to Uma, the consort of Lord Siva. For knowledge, one prays to Girisha. But if we keep praying for such things, when will we think of moksha? For moksha, we must pray to Lord Narayana, for He alone is capable of granting moksha.

When a person's life ends, the atma can take a path to *svarga* or the path to *Sri Vaikuntha*. The path to *svarga* is called *dumadi marga*. It is the path of darkness. We generally conceptualise *svarga* as a place of eternal happiness and pleasures. The truth is that the duration of our stay in *svarga* is proportional to our merits. Once our *punyas* are exhausted, we have to leave *svarga* and take birth again. So *svarga* does not save us from repeated birth, death and all the ills of worldly life. The path that the atma takes to reach *Sri Vaikuntha* is called *archiradi marga*. This is the path of light. And once we reach *Sri Vaikuntha*, our stay there is forever. No more births, deaths and involvement in the never-ending cycle of *samsara*.

Precious metals recover from early Feb. lows

B. Krishnakumar

The precious metal price staged a recovery off the lows recorded in early February. The recovery was primarily fuelled by the uncertainty over U.S. President Donald Trump’s tariff plans. The lower-than-expected U.S. GDP data also helped bolster sentiment towards precious metals. The lingering geopolitical tension in Iran also helped the cause.

Comex gold managed to claw its way back above the psychological \$5,000-mark and settled at \$5,296.4 by the end of February. This represents a 7.92% gain last month.

The price action in Comex silver was no different to that of gold with the white metal posting a 10.72% gain in February to settle at \$94.38 per ounce.

Mirroring the trend in the global markets, the MCX Gold price also recovered off the lows recorded earlier last month. MCX gold closed at ₹1,61,971 per 10-grams at the end of February, representing a 7.37% gain.

Unlike gold, MCX silver closed on a weak note in February. The white metal price closed 8.96% lower last month to settle at ₹2,81,990 per kilogram.

As anticipated last month, precious metals price remained range-bound and was confined to \$4,400-\$5,650 mentioned last month. While the long-term trend remains positive, the gold price is may still spend some time in this range before the long-term uptrend reasserts. Only a drop below



\$4,400 would be a cause of concern for the validity of the long-term uptrend. On the upside, the next major target is at \$5,650-\$5,700 for comex gold.

Similar to gold, comex silver price too was confined within the \$75-\$110 range mentioned last month. This range-bound price action is likely to persist until there is a clear breakout from this range. The long-term trend remains positive and the next major target for silver is \$125-\$135.

Domestic market

In the domestic market too, gold price was stuck in the ₹1,45,000-₹1,90,000 range mentioned last month.

Expect volatile back and forth movement within this zone to persist for the next few weeks. Though the long-term trend is still positive, the price has to breakout above ₹1,91,000 to trigger the move to the next target of ₹2,05,000-₹2,10,000.

MCX silver also was confined to the ₹2,40,000-₹3,85,000 zone that was mentioned last month. This range-bound price action is likely to continue in the near term. Only a breakout from the extremes of this zone would set the tone for the next big directional move. Until then expect volatile price action within this broad zone. The long-term target for silver is ₹3,95,000-₹4,15,000. The positive long-term view would be invalidated if the price falls below ₹2,30,000.

To summarise, both gold and silver have cooled off from overbought zone. The price action is likely to be confined to a broad trading range for the next several weeks.

(The author is a Chennai based analyst/trader. The views and opinion featured in this column is based on the analysis of short-term price movement in gold and silver futures at COMEX & Multi Commodity Exchange of India. This is not meant to be a trading or investment advice)

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.



Arbitrage funds are a category of hybrid mutual funds that seek to generate returns from short-lived price differences. GETTYIMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

Arbitrage funds: Profiting from price gaps in volatile market

Volatility is often equated with risk. Yet for arbitrage funds, turbulent markets can briefly expand price spreads, creating opportunities without taking directional bets

FUND FOCUS

Vaishali R Venkat

The next time you place an order to buy or sell a stock through your demat account, just pause and take a moment to glance at its price on the two exchanges – the National Stock Exchange (NSE) and the Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE). You might be surprised to find that the same stock is trading a few paise cheaper on one exchange than the other at that very moment, though not always. Thanks to the constant play of demand and supply.

The price gap is often so negligible that most investors barely notice it or ignore. For seasoned traders, however, such fleeting price mismatches can hint at something more: perhaps an ‘arbitrage’ opportunity, waiting to be captured. What an ordinary investor brushes past as just another volatile phase of the market, a veteran trader may see as a chance to lock in a small, calculated profit.

What is arbitrage?

To put it simply, the term arbitrage refers to the practice of capturing profit from price gaps, in the same asset (such as a stock) in two different markets or financial instruments. It involves a dual transaction of buying at a lower price and selling at a higher price at nearly the same time, thereby taking advantage of the spread between the prices. Since the trades are executed at nearly the same time, the arbitrage

When markets are volatile, the likelihood of price mismatches or gaps across exchanges or between the spot and the derivatives markets tends to increase

strategy does not rely on market predictions.

Arbitrage funds are a category of hybrid mutual funds that seek to generate returns from these short-lived price differences. Market watchdog Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) classifies arbitrage funds as equity-oriented funds and requires them to maintain at least 65% gross exposure to equities or equity-related securities. The unutilised portions of the portfolio are often invested in short-term debt or money-market instruments to manage liquidity and optimise overall returns.

Instead of attempting to predict the future direction of the market, whether bullish or bearish, arbitrage fund managers try to take advantage of the temporary price spreads in the same asset across markets or across instruments.

Arbitrage fund managers systematically buy a stock in the cash (spot) market at a lower price and sell its corresponding Futures contract in the derivatives market at a higher price. Alternatively, they may exploit small price differences across exchanges by buying a stock on the NSE and selling the same stock on the BSE, or vice versa. By executing numerous such trades, they try to

Arbitrage funds offer a market-linked, more flexible alternative with anytime redemption and generally no premature-withdrawal penalties

generate relatively steady returns.

Why volatility matters?

Manikandan Chandran, researcher and founder of Wincredible Technologies, says, “When markets are volatile, the likelihood of price mismatches or gaps across exchanges or between the spot and the derivatives markets tends to increase. When prices move in a jiffy, fleeting gaps emerge, creating opportunities for arbitrage trades.” He says that in relatively calm or sideways markets, such differences may be smaller or vanish more quickly, leaving only limited spreads or sometimes none at all.

Though arbitrage funds use hedged positions to reduce reliance on predicting market trends, they are not entirely risk-free. Their returns depend largely on the availability of pricing gaps, which can vary with market conditions and may sometimes be scarce or absent altogether. At times when spreads (price gaps) are narrow or opportunities are scarce, returns may be modest.

Short-term fluctuations may also occur if trades are not executed at the expected prices, if market liquidity is limited, or because of transaction costs. As a result, arbitrage funds are

generally not viewed as high-growth strategies but are instead considered to offer relatively stable, moderate returns.

Who can invest?

Arbitrage funds are generally considered suitable for investors seeking relatively stable returns without involving in market predictions.

They are often considered during uncertain or volatile market phases, when pricing gaps may arise more frequently. However, investors aiming for aggressive long-term growth or wealth creation may find these funds less suitable, as the strategy is not designed to deliver high equity-style growth.

Researcher Manikandan says that with most long-running arbitrage funds delivering about 6%-7% annualised returns on an average since inception, the category has historically behaved as a moderate, low-volatility return option rather than a high-growth equity strategy.

“Though FDs or RDs deliver similar returns, arbitrage funds offer a market-linked, more flexible alternative with easier anytime redemption and generally no premature-withdrawal penalties,” says Manikandan.

Markets are rarely perfectly aligned. Prices flicker, spreads appear and disappear, and in those brief moments of imbalance lie quiet possibilities. Arbitrage funds are designed to work within that space.

(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM’s Research Analyst module)

Rebalancing scenarios and rules

THINKINVESTOR

You should reduce equity allocation as you approach the time horizon for the goal; your equity investments are exposed to the risk of losing unrealised gains

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Previously in this column, we discussed the importance of rebalancing of goal-based portfolios. In this article, we lay out two scenarios that require rebalancing and briefly recap the rules for each scenario.

Why rebalance?

Rebalancing is the process of changing the asset allocation of your goal-based portfolios. Suppose you create your child’s education portfolio with an initial asset allocation of 60% equity and 40% bonds with a time horizon of 12 years. To keep the portfolio simple, let us suppose you invest in an ETF for your equity allocation and in bank recurring deposit for your bond allocation. So, the volatility in the portfolio’s returns can be primarily attributed to the equity allocation.

There are two reasons why rebalancing of this portfolio is important. One, you should reduce your equity allocation as you approach the time horizon for the goal. This is because any negative return in the equity market during the years approaching the goal can have a significant impact on your portfolio value and, therefore, on your life goal.

As a rule, for any life goal other than your retirement portfolio, it is best to apply the rebalancing process starting five years from the end of the time horizon for the goal. And two, your equity investments are exposed to the risk of losing unrealised gains.

Rebalancing can help you moderate this risk. The rebalancing rule can be determined thus: Arrive at a threshold return, which is one percentage point plus the expected pre-tax return on equity investments. When the actual return is greater than the threshold return, rebalance to the extent of the actual return less the pre-tax expected return. The rule for rebalancing is different for the two scenarios. But you may not have to rebalance every year, as you must trade-off two factors- the tax liability (typically, long-term capital gains tax) of rebalancing and the portfolio’s risk if not rebalanced. Note that the rebalancing rule for the second scenario already considers the tax liability by creating a threshold return. You could stagger the rebalancing process to reduce the tax liability for the first scenario. Here’s how: If two goal-based portfolios have entered the zone of rebalancing (five years discussed above), you may choose to rebalance one portfolio this year and the other the next year, depending on each portfolios’ excess returns. The objective is to make optimal use of any annual exemption limit applicable for long-term capital gains.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 3.5%
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
Bank of Baroda *	10.15-18.05	10,660-12,710	2,132-2,542	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Axis Bank	9.50 onwards	10,501 onwards	2,100 onwards	Up to 2%
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.15	10,550-11,934	2,110-2,387	0.50% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
HSBC Bank	9.95 onwards	10,611 onwards	2,122 onwards	Up to 2%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
Union Bank of India	8.75 - 12.55	10,319-11,262	2,064-2,252	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.00	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 3.93%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.60-13.85	10,525-11,595	2,105-2,319	0.50%-1%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Bank of Maharashtra	8.75-13.55	10,319-11,518	2,064-2,304	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Central Bank of India	9.85-11.65	10,587-11,034	2,117-2,207	Up to 1%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance.

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Union Bank of India	7.40-9.45	9,995 - 10,489	Up to Rs 1,000
Punjab National Bank	7.55-10.70	10,031 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Canara Bank	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
State Bank of India	8.90 - 9.85	10,355 - 10,587	Rs 750 - Rs 1,500
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	NIL
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
ICICI Bank	8.50 onwards	10,258 onwards	Up to 2%
HDFC Bank	8.20 onwards	10,186 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
Karnataka Bank	8.00-11.50	10,138 - 10,996	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Federal Bank	8.25 onwards	10,198 onwards	Rs. 2,000 - Rs. 4,500
Punjab and Sind Bank**	7.50-14.00	10,019 - 11,634	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Bank	7.50-9.55	10,019 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	Up to Rs. 10,000
Central Bank of India	7.60-9.20	10,043 - 10,428	No processing fees till 31.03.2026

*0.25% interest rate concession for home loan borrowers/other customers with at least 6 months relationship with bank

**Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam

Rates and charges as on February 25

Source: Paisabazaar.com

TEHRAN

Thousands gather in Iran’s capital, mourning Supreme Leader’s death



Thousands gathered in the centre of Tehran, on Sunday, mourning Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei’s death. The mourners, dressed mostly in black and some crying, chanted “death to America” and “death to Israel” in Revolution Square, with many waving Iran’s flags and holding photos of Khamenei. AFP

BEIRUT

Lebanon’s Hezbollah vows to ‘confront aggression’ of U.S., Israel



Lebanese militant group Hezbollah vowed on Sunday to confront the U.S. and Israel over their strikes on the group’s key backer Iran. “We will undertake our duty of confronting the aggression,” Hezbollah chief Naim Qassem said in a statement, adding that his movement would not leave “the field of honour and resistance”. AFP

MOSCOW

Putin calls Khamenei’s killing ‘cynical violation’ of ‘morality’



Russian President Vladimir Putin on Sunday slammed the United States and Israel’s killing of Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei as a “cynical violation” of morality and law. Russian Foreign Ministry called for “an immediate de-escalation, a cessation of hostilities, and a return to political and diplomatic process”. AFP

KABUL

Thwarted Pak. air strike attempt on Bagram Air Base: Afghanistan



Afghanistan said on Sunday it had thwarted attempted air strikes on Bagram Air Base, the former U.S. military base north of Kabul, while cross-border fighting between Pakistan and Afghanistan stretched into a fourth day. The statement said Afghan forces responded with “anti-aircraft and missile defence systems”. AP

Iran strikes on Israel kill 9; three U.S. service members dead, 5 hurt

Iran’s Revolutionary Guards launch large-scale attack, causing explosions in Riyadh, Dubai, Abu Dhabi, Doha, Manama, Jerusalem, Tel Aviv, with Saudi Arabia intercepting missiles; Pentagon denies Iran’s claim of striking *USS Abraham Lincoln*

Agence France-Presse
Reuters
DUBAI

Iran strikes on Israel killed at least nine persons and left 11 missing in the city of Beit Shmesh on Sunday, first responders said, as Iran vowed revenge after the killing of its Supreme Leader. Another 28 were wounded, the Magen David Adom emergency service said. The police said there was a direct hit on a building.

Three members of the U.S. military have been killed and five others seriously wounded in the operation against Iran, the



Slipping past Dome: An explosion caused by a projectile impact after Iran launched missiles into Israel, in Tel Aviv. REUTERS

Pentagon said on Sunday, announcing the first American deaths in the U.S.-Israeli campaign.

Iran’s Revolutionary Guards announced a

Iran’s President Masoud Pezeshkian declared Khamenei’s killing a “declaration of war against Muslims” and warned: “Iran considers it its legitimate duty and right to avenge the perpetrators and masterminds of this historic crime.”

U.S. defence systems intercepted at least two drones over the city of Erbil in northern Iraq, as sirens sounded from the American consulate.

Saudi Arabia intercepted Iranian missiles targeting Riyadh’s international airport and the Prince Sultan Airbase, which houses U.S. military personnel, a Gulf source said, adding

that the interception did not disrupt navigation or cause any human or material losses. Dubai, Abu Dhabi, Kuwait and Manama airports were also targeted by attacks.

Meanwhile, The Pentagon denied Iran’s claim to have struck the aircraft carrier *USS Abraham Lincoln* with ballistic missiles in the Gulf. “The Lincoln was not hit. The missiles launched didn’t even come close,” U.S. Central Command said on X.

Elsewhere, OPEC+ agreed a modest oil output boost of 2,06,000 barrels per day for April as the U.S.-Israeli war on Iran disrupted oil flows.

At least 22 killed, over 120 hurt in protests across Pak.

Associated Press
KARACHI

Violent clashes between protesters and security forces in Pakistan’s port city of Karachi and in the country’s north on Sunday left at least 22 people dead and more than 120 others injured in pro-Iran demonstrations, authorities said.

At least 10 people were killed in firing in Karachi when protesters tried to storm the U.S. Consulate in the port city. Police said that at least 40 people were also wounded in the clashes and some of them were in critical condition.

Twelve people were killed and over 80 wounded in clashes with police in the northern Gilgit-Baltistan region when thousands of Shia protesters attacked the offices of the UN Mil-



Protesters engaging in a clash with security forces outside the U.S. Consulate in Karachi, Pakistan on Sunday. REUTERS

tary Observer Group and the UN Development Programme (UNDP), local police official Asghar Ali said.

The U.S. Embassy in Islamabad said it is monitoring reports of ongoing demonstrations even as Pakistan’s Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi requested the citizens not to take the law into their hands, and “record protest peacefully”.

Meanwhile, Pakistan’s Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said that the killing of Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei was a “violation” of international law.

President Asif Ali Zardari also expressed his “profound sorrow over the martyrdom of Khamenei” and conveyed his condolences to Iran.

As Rubio drives Trump’s war agenda, Vance and MAGA base are confused

NEWS ANALYSIS
Varghese K. George

U.S. Vice-President J.D. Vance and Secretary of State Marco Rubio represent different worldviews within the Make America Great Again (MAGA) universe, though both present their politics in terms of Christian civilisational nationalism. A fundamental principle of MAGA politics has been an opposition to America’s “endless wars” – the phrase Mr. Trump deployed in three consecutive election campaigns.

In his 2025 inaugural address, he declared that the power of the U.S. “will stop all wars and bring a new spirit of unity to a world that has been angry, violent and totally unpredictable”. Mr. Trump touted not starting a new war as a big achievement of his first term. Mr. Vance is a MAGA native on the war question, while Mr. Rubio was a late, reluctant convert. The new American war in West Asia marks an eclipse of Mr. Vance and the prominence of Mr. Rubio. The MAGA base lay scattered and orphaned as their messiah, Mr. Trump, has himself abandoned the flock and joined the pipers of war.



Donald Trump with J.D. Vance, left, and Marco Rubio during the inaugural meeting of the Board of Peace in Washington. AFP

strife within Christian societies and reclaiming them from godless globalist liberals.

In Mr. Vance’s worldview, the restoration of nationalism is an internal process for each country to undertake, and the U.S. must look within and restore itself rather than get involved in any other region or country, regardless of how strong the moral case could be. Russia, in the Vance side of the MAGA worldview, is a civilisational ally, not an adversary.

Mr. Rubio arrived at the same podium a year later, in February 2026, and inhabited a different universe entirely. Mr. Rubio always considered the Christian mission as a global enterprise to be helmed by the West. “We are part of one civilization – Western civilization,” Mr. Rubio declared at the MSC.

For five centuries until 1945, he said, the West had been expanding. Mr. Rubio echoed MAGA talking points against global institutions, the decline of mass manufacturing, and mass migration in the West, but his speech stood in stark contrast to Mr. Vance’s on the emphasis of rectification.

lowed out, faith mocked. His anti-interventionism was always a consequence of this worldview. For a while, the contradiction between the two coexisted inside the same administration. Mr. Trump’s campaign had cast him as the peace candidate.

Neoncon project

The war against Iran has ended the ambiguity. A war against Iran was always the neoconservative project – the final item on a checklist that began in Afghanistan, continued in Iraq, detoured through Libya and Syria, and always had Tehran as its terminus. The architects of that project were never really gone. They regrouped, rebranded and waited. Mr. Rubio had not converted himself to the MAGA slogans he professed for the crowd, it turns out. He has instead converted the MAGA messiah himself – Mr. Trump, no less.

MAGA’s anti-war base is orphaned. Former Congresswoman Marjorie Taylor Greene, one of Mr. Trump’s most loyal campaigners, put it with characteristic bluntness, when the war was about to begin: “[F]or some unknown reason, Trump has joined the neocons and will soon go to war against Iran. End of MAGA.”

The call for internal restoration, and the liberation of the Christian nation from globalists as preached at MAGA pulpits, are now muffled under the renewed campaign for global civilisational dominance that Mr. Rubio spoke about in Munich. The flock has been told, by the man it trusted most, that it was wrong about what he believed.

THE HINDU GROUP

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DAY OF DAYS

India set to make record-equalling sixth appearance in T20 WC semis



K.R. DEEPAK

India has reached the T20 World Cup semifinals for a record-equalling sixth time. The Men in Blue had also made it to the last-four stage in 2007, 2014, 2016, 2022 and 2024. Meanwhile, India on Sunday recorded its highest successful chase in the marquee tournament. It was also the third-best overall.

MAXIMUM IMPACT

Powell becomes first Windies cricketer to hit 150 T20I sixes



K.R. DEEPAK

Rovman Powell, who scored an unbeaten 34 on Sunday, became the first West Indian to reach the landmark of 150 sixes in T20Is. He achieved it in his 103rd innings and overtook Nicholas Pooran, who smacked 149 sixes in 97 innings. With 2,261 runs, Powell is Windies' second-highest run-getter in the format behind Pooran (2,275 runs).

FORGETTABLE ENDING

Jayasuriya decides to step down as Sri Lanka's head coach



AP

Sanath Jayasuriya has decided to step down as Sri Lanka's head coach in the wake of the team's abysmal performance in the T20 World Cup. "My contract ends in June but I will go before that. I will talk to Sri Lanka Cricket about my decision to step down," Jayasuriya said after Sri Lanka lost all three Super Eight matches.

STRANDED

No clarity on travel plans, says Zimbabwe coach Sammons



B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

In the wake of the Iran-Israel conflict that has led to the shutting of the airspace over the Middle-East, Zimbabwe head coach Justin Sammons said the team is awaiting clarity on its travel plans to return home after its exit from the T20 World Cup on Sunday. "We haven't heard anything yet," Sammons said in New Delhi.

Samson delivers at the crunch as India enters semis

The opener's unbeaten 50-ball 97 guides the Men in Blue past Windies in a final-over finish; Holder's all-round effort not enough for the Caribbean side; the host sets up a last-four clash with England

T20 WORLD CUP

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
KOLKATA

Sanju Samson (97 n.o.) was the spine as India held its nerve on a Sunday of delight at the Eden Gardens. The Men in Blue defeated the West Indies by five wickets in the ICC T20 Super Eight Group 1 match and sealed their semifinal berth. Chasing the visitor's 195 for four, India finished with 199 for five in 19.2 overs.

Once India commenced its pursuit, Abhishek Sharma guided a four off Akeal Hosein. Samson cut loose against the left-arm spinner, picking a four, slog-sweeping a six, and yet the host was soon in a spot of bother.

Vital stand

Both Abhishek and Ishan Kishan holed out in the deep and Shimron Hetmyer, the fielder, revealed safe hands.

At 41 for two, the defending champion needed an alliance and Samson and Suryakumar Yadav stitched one worth 58. Samson carved his fifty and his skipper flicked a six off Jason Holder.

However, Suryakumar found Sherfane Rutherford on the fence. Samson battled on, often finding the fence, and Tilak Varma gave him support. The two



Sensational stuff: Samson thanks the heavens after his sublime innings sealed India's semifinal berth. K.R. DEEPAK



played along the turf, a Shamar Joseph over yielded a bouquet of fours, and Tilak launched Roston Chase into the stands. Just as India seemed to be in the hunt, Tilak failed to get past Hetmyer. It boiled down to 50 from 30,

but Hardik Pandya and Shivam Dube did their bit and fittingly Samson hit the winning runs. He slumped into the turf with arms aloft. It was a moment that

SCOREBOARD

WEST INDIES

Shai Hope b Varun 32 (33b, 3x4, 1x6), Roston Chase c Suryakumar b Bumrah 40 (25b, 5x4, 1x6), Shimron Hetmyer c Samson b Bumrah 27 (12b, 1x4, 2x6), Sherfane Rutherford c Samson b Hardik 14 (9b, 1x6), Rovman Powell (not out) 34 (19b, 3x4, 2x6), Jason Holder (not out) 37 (22b, 2x4, 3x6); Extras (lb-1, w-10); 11; Total (for four wkts. in 20 overs): 195.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-68 (Hope, 8.5 overs), 2-102 (Hetmyer, 11.3), 3-103 (Chase, 11.5), 4-119 (Rutherford, 14.1).

INDIA BOWLING

Arshdeep 4-0-43-0, Hardik 4-0-40-1, Axar 4-0-35-0, Bumrah 4-0-36-2, Varun 4-0-40-1.

INDIA

Abhishek Sharma c Hetmyer b Hosein 10 (11b, 2x4), Sanju

Samson (not out) 97 (50b, 12x4, 4x6), Ishan Kishan c Hetmyer b Holder 10 (6b, 2x4), Suryakumar Yadav c Rutherford b Joseph 18 (16b, 1x4, 1x6), Tilak Varma c Hetmyer b Holder 27 (15b, 4x4, 1x6), Hardik Pandya c Holder b Joseph 17 (14b, 2x4), Shivam Dube (not out) 8 (4b, 2x4); Extras (lb-5, w-7); 12; Total (for five wkts. in 19.2 overs): 199.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-29 (Abhishek, 2.6), 2-41 (Kishan, 4.3), 3-99 (Suryakumar, 10.2), 4-141 (Tilak, 14.4), 5-179 (Hardik, 18.2).

WEST INDIES BOWLING

Hosein 2-0-22-1, Forde 3-0-22-0, Holder 4-0-38-2, Motie 2-0-18-0, Shepherd 2.2-0-34-0, Joseph 4-0-42-2, Chase 2-0-18-0.

Toss: India; **PoM:** Samson.

India won by five wickets with four balls to spare.

encapsulated relief and ecstasy. Earlier, Suryakumar won the toss, elected to field and found an adhesive quality in the West Indies openers Shai Hope and Chase.

Shifting gears

Skipper Hope led the charts with a six and four off Hardik. Chase too shifted gears with a four off Arshdeep Singh.

A drive was also esayed, and when Jasprit Bumrah steamed in, he was reverse scooped.

Hardik was whipped for six and just as Chase accelerated, Varun Chakaravathy castled Hope.

West Indies had 68, and Hetmyer swatted two sixes, one each off Hardik and Varun.

Quick wickets

Bumrah then lured an edge from Hetmyer and forced Chase into a mis-cued shot. And Hardik prised out Rutherford as West Indies lost some momentum.

But Rovman Powell and Holder had other ideas. The duo's unbeaten 76 runs partnership was built upon mighty sixes. The West Indies had indeed gained a combative score but Samson owned the night. Now England awaits India at Mumbai on Thursday.

Samson is a world-class player and he paced his innings well: Gambhir



Wily operator: Bumrah's double-wicket over pegged the West Indies back. K.R. DEEPAK

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
KOLKATA

Gautam Gambhir does know a thing or two about chases. In the 2011 World Cup final against Sri Lanka, he top-scored with a 97 in a winning cause. Cut to the present, in his avatar as the coach, the former India opener was thrilled with another 97, this time scored by Sanju Samson.

"Sanju is a world-class player, he has the experience and he did very well. Even in that game against Zimbabwe he did his part. I didn't think he

accelerated, he just paced his innings well here, played smartly. I hope he builds on from here. In Sanju and Ishan Kishan, we have two very good players, who can both bat and keep wickets," Gambhir said.

The coach was quick to stress that the victory against the West Indies in a vital ICC T20 World Cup game, had the hallmark of teamwork: "Sanju scored 97 but we also had Shivam Dube scoring those two fours in the penultimate over. Jasprit Bumrah is our banker, we keep going

Final Super Eight Table							
GROUP 1				Q: QUALIFIED			
	M	W	L	NR	PTS	NRR	
South Africa (Q)	3	3	0	0	6	2.259	
India (Q)	3	2	1	0	4	0.106	
West Indies	3	1	2	0	2	0.993	
Zimbabwe	3	0	3	0	0	-3.415	
GROUP 2							
	M	W	L	NR	PTS	NRR	
England (Q)	3	3	0	0	6	1.096	
New Zealand (Q)	3	1	1	1	3	1.390	
Pakistan	3	1	1	1	3	-0.123	
Sri Lanka	3	0	3	0	0	-1.950	
THE CLIMACTIC PHASE							
SEMIFINALS							
■ March 4: South Africa vs. New Zealand, Kolkata, 7 p.m.							
■ March 5: India vs. England, Mumbai, 7 p.m.							
FINAL: MARCH 8: Ahmedabad, 7 p.m.							

back to him. In the chase, we never felt we were out of the game."

Asked how the team decides the batting combination and bowling changes, Gambhir said: "It is all about experience, I think data is over-rated, you just figure things, and yes the captain makes his decisions. And in big matches, it all boils down to mental strength."

West Indies skipper Shai Hope also lauded Samson's knock: "It was an A-plus innings. He is an experienced player and he handled the chase well."

Having helmed a reasonably good campaign, Hope said: "Our bowlers did well and we batted deep. Shimron Hetmyer at three was good. Obviously we will analyse why we lost".

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

South Africa's collective might trumped Zimbabwe skipper Sikandar Raza's individual brilliance on a hot Sunday afternoon at the Arun Jaitley Stadium here.

In their final Super Eight Group 1 fixture of the 2026 T20 World Cup, the Proteas chased down 154 with five wickets in hand to maintain their perfect record in the competition. Aiden Markram and Co. will take on New Zealand in the semifinals in Kolkata on Wednesday.

Raza, who will turn 40 in April, was peerless on the day. After hammering 73 off 43 balls, he also snared three scalps with his off-breaks. Having taken the new ball, he induced Quinton de Kock's edge in the very first over, and castled Markram with a ball that kept a tad low in the third over.

When Ryan Rickelton miscued a pull off Brad Evans to Ryan Burl at long-on in the sixth over, South Africa was in a spot of bother at 43 for three.



Positive intent: Brevis eased nerves in the South African camp with a match-winning 42 off just 18 balls. R.V. MOORTHY

But Dewald Brevis and David Miller brought a degree of comfort to the chase by adding 50 off 25

ny as four sixes in his 18-ball 42.

While the dismissals of Miller and Brevis in quick succession added a layer of intrigue to the climax, Tristan Stubbs and George Linde ensured there were no further hiccups.

Earlier, Raza was at the front and centre of Zimbabwe's total of 153 for seven. Even as wickets fell frequently at the other end, the 39-year-old continued to play with abandon until his dismissal in the 17th over.

Having walked in to bat when Zimbabwe was 28 for two in the fifth over, he pounced particularly when the South African pacers erred on the shorter side.

He galloped to his half-century off 29 balls, but negligible support from the rest meant it was all in vain.

The scores:

Zimbabwe 153/7 in 20 overs (Sikandar Raza 73, Kwen Maphaka 2/21, Corbin Bosch 2/40) lost to South Africa 154/5 in 17.5 overs (Ryan Rickelton 31, Dewald Brevis 42, George Linde 30 n.o., Sikandar Raza 3/29).

Toss: Zimbabwe; **PoM:** Raza.



Rising high: Timber, third left, nods home Arsenal's winner against Chelsea. AFP

Arsenal keeps five-point lead with a nervy win

Timber's header ensures victory over Chelsea; Yamal hat-trick fires Barcelona to a comfortable win over Villarreal; Atletico edges Oviedo

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Arsenal reestablished a five-point lead at the top of the Premier League with a 2-1 win over 10-man Chelsea 2-1 on Sunday, while Benjamin Sesko fired Manchester United up to third with victory over Crystal Palace.

Defenders William Saliba and Jurrien Timber got Arsenal's goals.

The Blues could not cope with Arsenal's prowess from corners as Mikel Arteta's men edged closer to a first league title in 22 years.

Earlier on Saturday, Manchester City had closed to within two points of Arsenal with a 1-0 win at

Leeds. City still has a game in hand on Arsenal.

Barcelona's teenage star Lamine Yamal scored the first hat-trick of his career in a 4-1 win over Villarreal on Saturday that took the Catalan giant four points clear at the top of La Liga.

Atletico Madrid moved third, level on points with Villarreal, after Julian Alvarez snatched it a 1-0 win at bottom side Real Oviedo.

The results: Premier League: Brighton 2 (Gomez 6, Welbeck 15) bt Nottingham Forest 1 (Gibbs-White 13); Fulham 2 (Wilson 7, Iwobi 34) bt Tottenham 1 (Richarlison 66). Manchester United 2 (Fernandes 57-pen, Sesko 65) bt Crystal Palace 1 (Lacroix 4); Arsenal 2 (Saliba 21, Timber 66) bt Chelsea 1 (Hincapie 45+2-og).

Serie A: Cremonese 0 lost to AC Milan 2 (Pavlovic 90, Leao 90+4); Sassuolo 2 (Kone 23, Thorstvedt 69) bt Atalanta 1 (Musah 88).

On Saturday: Premier League: Burnley 3 (Kayode 45+3-og, Anthony 47, Flemming 60) lost to Brentford 4 (Damsgaard 9, 90+3, Thiago 25, Schade 34). Liverpool 5 (Ekitike 5, Van Dijk 24, Mac Allister 43, Gakpo 70, Disasi 82-og) bt West Ham 2 (Soucek 49, Castellanos 75). Newcastle 2 (Ramsey 32, Murphy 82) lost to Everton 3 (Branthwaite 19, Beto 34, Barry 83); Leeds 0 lost to Manchester City 1 (Semenyo 45+2).

LaLiga: Barcelona 4 (Yamal 28, 37, 69, Lewandowski 90+1) bt Villarreal 1 (Gueye 49); Real Oviedo 0 lost to Atletico Madrid 1 (Alvarez 90+4).

Serie A: Inter Milan 2 (Dimarco 31, Calhanoglu 70-pen) bt Genoa 0; Verona 1 (Akpa Akpro 64) lost to Napoli 2 (Hojlund 2, Lukaku 90+5).

Bundesliga: Borussia Dortmund 2 (Schlotterbeck 26, Svensson 83) lost to Bayern Munich 3 (Kane 54, 70-pen, Kimmich 87).

Hoffenheim 0 lost to St. Pauli 1 (Pereira Lage 45+4); Bayer Leverkusen 1 (Quansah 88) drew with Mainz 1 (Becker 67).

Chennaiyin, Odisha play out a draw



Breaking the duck: Chennaiyin's Brazilian defender Elsinho, centre, scored his first goal in the ISL. X@CHENNAIYNFC

ISL

Sports Bureau

Centre-backs Elsinho and Carlos Delgado showed the attackers how to get on the scoresheet as Chennaiyin FC and Odisha FC shared the spoils in the Indian Super League contest at the Kalinga Stadium in Bhubaneswar on Sunday.

Elsinho and Delgado, picked in the team primarily for their defensive prowess, scored off set-pieces for Chennaiyin and Odisha respectively in the 1-1 stalemate. While CFC opened its account on its third attempt, OFC played out its second successive draw.

Chennaiyin was lucky not to be reduced to 10 men in the 26th minute, when Laldinliana Renthlei, being the last man, brought down Rahim Ali during an Odisha counter-attack. The right-back escaped a send-off after the referee perhaps took into consideration where the foul was committed (close to the halfway line).

The deadlock was broken by Elsinho's pin-point header on the stroke of

half-time. Farukh Choudhary delivered a sumptuous corner-kick to pick out the Brazilian, who rose the highest to bag his first goal in Indian football. The piece of Samba magic also enabled Chennaiyin unlock a few firsts – it was the club's maiden goal of the ISL season and the first by an outfield player under head coach Clifford Miranda.

Odisha showed urgency at the start of the second period and went on to level the score through Delgado (68th). The Spanish central defender matched Elsinho's effort, beating his marker Pritam Kotal and heading in a precise cross from Puitea off a free-kick.

Inigo Martin and substitute Imran Khan had golden opportunities to restore the lead for CFC, but both missed from close range. In the end, the teams shook hands with a point each.

The results: **At Bhubaneswar:** Odisha FC 1 (Carlos Delgado 68) drew with Chennaiyin FC 1 (Elsinho 45+2).

At Mumbai: Mumbai City 1 (Lallianzuala Chhangte 85) drew with NorthEast United 1 (M.S. Jithin 48).

Shaina wins bronze at Dutch Jr. Intl.

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

India's rising shuttler Shaina Manimuthu has secured

a bronze medal at the Dutch Junior International. Shaina, the under-15 girls' champion at the Badminton Asia Champion-

ships, saw her impressive run end in the semifinals, where she went down to China's Yi Qing Yin 17-21, 8-21 in 35 minutes.

ZIMBABWE'S SECOND COMING

ON STANDS NOW!

After missing out in 2024, Zimbabwe clawed through qualifiers and stunned giants in the 2026 T20 World Cup, rediscovering belief and balance.

Also in this issue:
Associate nations demand a bigger global stage after near-upsets in the T20 World Cup

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Meghana Sajjanar's bronze-winning precision proves resilience can steady even the most delicate aim.

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Ponmythili Muralidharan

During exam season, certain things repeat themselves in almost every home. A student sitting at the dining table late into the night. A cup of tea gone cold. Notes spread out, not always being read. A parent hovering nearby, unsure whether to speak or stay silent.

From the outside, it looks like stress. From the inside, it feels like learning something that no textbook ever names. During this time, students often answer the same question again and again.

“How are you?”
“I’m fine.”

It is said while tying shoelaces in a hurry, while eating without much appetite, or while stepping out of the exam hall and avoiding eye contact. Often, “I’m fine” means I’m managing.

Beyond textbooks

Exams do not only test what students know. They slowly train students to stay with effort. To sit with discomfort without walking away. To return to the same chapter even when confidence dips and motivation feels thin.

Many students remember this phase not because of a particular question, but because of how it felt. The heaviness in the chest before an exam. The strange quiet of



Life lessons from exams

With exam season upon us, an educator reflects on what students actually learn and carry forward from this period of stress

the hall. The moment of doubt halfway through a paper when the mind goes blank and yet the hand keeps moving. That moment matters.

After the exam, the managing does not stop. Outside the hall, conversations begin quickly.

“That question was easy.” or “I think the answer is option C.”

Some students listen and feel unsettled. Some

quietly walk away. Some put on earphones even if no music is playing. Choosing not to participate in these conversations takes effort. It is not avoidance. It is self-control, and many students practise it daily during exam season.

Two students can score the same marks and yet come away with very different inner experiences. One may have

had reassurance at home, steady encouragement, and the sense that outcomes were not the only thing being watched. Another may have carried unspoken pressure. The fear of letting someone down. The feeling that failure was not an option.

Manage responsibility

What exams reveal quietly is not who is

smarter, but who learns to carry responsibility early. Most students learn this without anyone spelling it out.

They learn how to manage tiredness. How to keep going even when sleep is patchy and days blur into each other. How to hold their nerves when comparison enters the room through rank lists, coaching centre stories, or a relative's ca-

sual comment.

They also learn how to appear fine. Many students become experts at saying “I’m okay” even when they are not. They learn that discipline is admired, but doubt is inconvenient. That calm is appreciated, but questions about fear or fatigue are harder to place. Over time, composure becomes a habit. This is not a weakness. It is an adaptation.

What often makes the difference is whether this effort is seen. When a parent notices persistence instead of only marks, the strain feels meaningful. When effort is invisible, pressure feels heavier than it needs to be.

Most adults can trace something important back to their exam years. The first time they realised they could do something difficult without quitting. The first time, they understood what sustained effort felt like. The first time they learned that clarity does not always come before action, sometimes it comes after. These lessons did not stay in school. They travelled forward.

Many adults forget this. They remember the stress, but not the strength it built. Yet the ability to sit with discomfort, to stay with effort, and to continue without immediate clarity was learned much earlier than they realise. Often, it was first practised during exam season.

Training ground

That is why exam pressure should not be spoken about only as suffering. It is also a training ground. Not because pressure is good in itself, but because learning to hold pressure with dignity builds something lasting.

Support during exam season does not mean removing difficulty. It means making the difficulty feel held. It shows up in small ways. In reducing unnecessary comparisons. In recognising effort even on days when results are unclear. In allowing a student to say, “This is hard”, without immediately trying to fix it.

Exams will end. Papers will be corrected. Life will move on. What stays is quieter. The memory of having stood in that heat and endured. The knowledge that, even at a young age, one learned to carry responsibility and finish what was started. Later, when life demands rigour again – as it will – something familiar returns. A sense of alignment.

I have done this before. I have stayed with something difficult before. If I could do it then, I can do it now. That is what exams do not test, but what students carry forward.

The writer is Junior Faculty Organisation - Behaviour and Human Resource at Great Lakes Institute of Management, Chennai.

SCHOLARSHIPS

Vivo Kanya Gyaan Scholarship

A CSR initiative by vivo India.

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Rewards: ₹60,000 a year

Application: Online

Deadline: March 3

www.b4s.in/edge/VKGSP1

CSIR-CCMB Summer Training

Provided by the CSIR-Centre for Cellular and Molecular Biology.

Eligibility: Students in the first year of M.Sc., M.Tech or M.Pharm, or those in B.Tech., B.Pharm, or Integrated Science and Technology programmes, MBBS BDS or B.Sc. Bioscience.

Rewards: Research experience and mentorship .

Application: Online

Deadline: March 10

www.b4s.in/edge/CCMB2

Ireland International Education Scholarship

An initiative of the Government of Ireland, in partnership with the Irish HEIs and managed by the Higher Education Authority.

Eligibility: Open to domiciled residents of non-EU/EEA countries who are graduates and hold a conditional or final admission offer to an Irish institution at the time of application.

Rewards: Up to €10,000 for a year.

Application: Online

Deadline: March 12

www.b4s.in/edge/ITES2

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

From the valley to the pinnacle of domestic cricket – the J & K story

Jammu & Kashmir's stellar run is a tale of grit, determination and meticulous preparation; it had all bases covered and every member of the squad put his hand up when it mattered most; the next challenge for Dogra's men will be to sustain the momentum and stay at the summit

Tarun Shastry

The location: absolutely picturesque. The people: warm and cordial. The culture: vibrant. But that's precisely where the niceties dissolve. Confront them on an unforgiving 22-yard strip, and the warmth hardens into will, the smiles fade into steely stare-downs.

Ask domestic powerhouse and 42-time champion Mumbai. Ask two-time titleholder Rajasthan. Ask two-time winner Hyderabad. Ask five-time titlist Madhya Pradesh. Ask former title holder, Bengal. Now include eight-time powerhouse Karnataka.

Each will narrate a different battle. Different sessions seized. Defining moments wrested away. Yet the conclusion remains chillingly consistent – Jammu and Kashmir are fierce, relentless, and unapologetically serious about their craft. Now perched at the summit of the nation's premier red-ball competition – the Ranji Trophy – they stand tall, composed, and commanding after overpowering Karnataka's celebrated batting unit in the final. From the valleys to the pinnacle of Indian domestic cricket, they have earned their place at the top. Every remarkable journey needs heroes – and for J & K, they have come in numbers. Meet the protagonists. The men on the field, and just as importantly off it, who have crafted this story to near perfection.

Auqib Nabi: *The Baramulla Express* has been central to J & K's historic triumph. Over the past two seasons, 2024-25 and 2025-26, he has derailed one side after another, establishing himself as the spearhead of a team that had never previously reached the top four in any competition.

He hasn't merely been effective; he has transformed J & K's bowling identity. In the final at Hubballi, Nabi rose to the grandest stage. He dismissed accomplished Test batters K.L. Rahul and Karun Nair with deliveries of the highest quality – both pitched on a probing length, kissed the seam, and shaped away just enough. Rahul could only feather a faint edge, while Nair's furniture disturbed as he stood momentarily stunned. Nabi wasn't done. He went on to claim three more wickets, including the home side's lone centurion, Mayank Agarwal and leading run-scorer R. Smaran, effectively breaking the backbone of Karnataka's resistance.

This season, Nabi finished as the leading wicket-taker with 60 scalps. Across the two campaigns combined, he has amassed a staggering 104 wickets. In this period, he has registered 13 five-wicket hauls in just 18 matches. He became the first J & K bowler to claim 50-plus wickets in a single Ranji season and the first from the state to top the tournament's bowling charts. Notably, he had already set a benchmark the previous year with 44 wickets.

In 2025-26 alone, Nabi recorded eight five-wicket hauls – the joint-most by any pacer in a first-class season in India. Only Maurice Tate (1926-27) and Ron Oxenham (1935-36) have matched that mark.

Such sustained excellence has inevitably sparked widespread clamour from stalwarts of the game, calling for his inclusion in the National side – and rightly so.

Sunil Kumar: *The Silent Warrior* has provided unwavering support from the other end. The 26-year-old left-arm seamer was a study in control throughout the season, operating with precision, patience and discipline. His ability to land the ball in probing areas, over after over, created the pressure that allowed breakthroughs to follow.

While the spotlight often tilted elsewhere, Sunil's quiet spells squeezed opposition batters into mistakes. He concluded the campaign with 31 wickets, including two five-wicket hauls – numbers that reflect both consistency and craft. Understated in demeanour, Sunil has gone about his work without fanfare. If one end brought the thunder, the other ensured the storm never relented.

Abdul Samad: *The Middle-Order Mauler's* immense skill, range, and potential flickered in phases. This season, it burned bright. If J & K had the arsenal to dismantle sides with the ball, they required a pillar with the bat to stack up the runs. Samad answered that call.

Often branded a white-ball player, the 24-year-old reshaped that perception in the recently concluded campaign. His red-ball game displayed maturity, patience, and a willingness to graft –



K. MURALI KUMAR

qualities that added depth and assurance to the batting order.

Samad finished as the team's highest run-scorer, amassing 748 runs in 10 matches at an impressive average of 57.53, including a century and five half-centuries. In the final, his composed 61 off 104 deliveries played a crucial role in powering J & K to a formidable 584.

Beyond the numbers, it was his temperament that stood out. Batting in the middle order, Samad provided stability in testing phases, absorbing pressure and constructing vital partnerships. Whether in the high-stakes final or in knockout clashes against Madhya Pradesh in the quarterfinal and Bengal in the semifinal, he delivered when it mattered most.

Paras Dogra: *The Veteran and Leader's* journey in the Ranji Trophy began in 2002. Having represented Himachal Pradesh and Puducherry over a career spanning more than two decades, the seasoned campaigner finally realised a long-cherished dream – lifting the Ranji Trophy as captain of Jammu & Kashmir.

He will forever be remembered as the first skipper to guide J & K to a Ranji title. At 41, Dogra brought far more than runs to the table. His leadership, calm authority, and vast domestic experience offered direction and balance to a side scripting history. In tense phases, his presence steadied the dressing room; in defining moments, his bat did the talking.

Dogra ended the season as J & K's second-highest run-scorer, compiling 637 runs in 10 matches at an average of 42.46, with two centuries and four half-centuries. This season also marked a personal milestone – Dogra crossed the 10,000-run mark in the Ranji Trophy, becoming only the second batter after former India opener Wasim Jaffer to reach that landmark in the tournament's history.

Qamran Iqbal: *The Blaster's* appearance in the final was dramatic. Having featured in the earlier rounds, he was not part of the squad for the knockouts. But a last-minute injury to regular opener Shubham Khajuria forced the team management to fly him to Hubballi on the eve of the title clash – a sudden call that handed him a historic opportunity.

Qamran responded emphatically. In the second essay, he produced a monumental unbeaten 160 off 311 deliveries, after his side was reduced to 31 for two. It was an innings of endurance and authority, one that knocked out Karnataka.

Across the tournament, Qamran amassed 471 runs in six matches at an average of 58.87, including two centuries and two fifties. But it was that

defining knock in the final – arriving as a last-minute replacement – that will permanently be written in J & K's cricketing folklore.

Shubham Pundir: *The Grinder* was another vital cog in the J & K wheel. Heading into Hubballi, his place in the XI was under scrutiny following modest returns in the quarterfinal and semifinal against Madhya Pradesh and Bengal.

Pundir answered – with runs. Walking in at No. 3, he crafted a resolute 121 in the first innings of the final, anchoring the batting effort and steering J & K to a mammoth total. It was an innings built on patience, discipline, and determination, laying a rock-solid foundation for what would become a title-winning performance. He was rightly adjudged Player of the Match for his defining century. In the 2025-26 Ranji season, Pundir accumulated 330 runs in four matches, including two hundreds, at an average of 47.14 – a grinder who delivered when it mattered most.

Sahil Lotra: *The Middle- and Lower-Order Punisher* was as decisive as the other headline-makers. Coming into the summit clash, he rose magnificently.

In the first innings, Sahil struck a vital 72, providing valuable momentum from the middle order and helping push the total to imposing heights. If that was important, what followed was extraordinary. In the second, he compiled a commanding unbeaten 101. Alongside Qamran, he stitched an unbroken 197-run partnership for the fifth wicket, a stand that flattened Karnataka's hopes and sealed the title.

Abid Mushtaq: *The All-Round Engine* ensured that J & K chugged along merrily to a historic Ranji Trophy triumph. An all-rounder in the truest sense, Mushtaq provided the balance every champion side requires – steady runs in the lower middle-order and timely

breakthroughs with the ball.

This season, he amassed 445 runs in 10 matches at an average of 37.08, including a century and a half-century. With the ball, he was equally dependable, claiming 20 wickets at an average of 31.75 and maintaining a tidy economy rate of 3.20. His five-wicket haul during the campaign underlined his ability to influence games with more than just control. Mushtaq's consistent presence across disciplines ensured J & K were never one-dimensional. His all-round impact stitched the campaign together, playing a crucial part in transforming a dream into a landmark achievement.

Ajay Sharma: *The Monk, Mentor and Motivator* always remained a step ahead of the opponent(s). A stalwart, who scored over 10,000 First Class runs and picked up crucial wickets during his playing career, the head coach brought a treasure trove of experience to the team – yet chose to lead quietly from behind the scenes, observing, guiding, and fine-tuning every detail.

Known for his strict discipline, Ajay demanded focus and commitment from every player. Initially, the squad found his methods exacting, even daunting. But as trust grew, so did their performance. His combination of rigorous preparation, tactical acumen and belief in the players has been instrumental in shaping his team into a formidable force.

Krishna Kumar: *The Miracle Maker* was instrumental in shaping the bowling unit into the potent force it has become. Much of the transformation happened away from the spotlight – in long pre-season sessions that began as early as the All India Buchi Babu tournament in Chennai last August. It is no coincidence that bowlers like Nabi, Sunil, Yudhvir Singh and others have evolved into a lethal pack. Behind their sharp spells lies meticulous planning, clarity of roles, and relentless preparation, thanks to the former Rajasthan pacer's influence as the bowling coach.

In a chat with the *The Hindu* during the Ranji season, he underlined what sets the side apart. "Unity is the key. We're bonding very well. If someone makes a mistake, we don't criticise them, we encourage them. The dressing room environment is fantastic. Earlier, some small aspects were ignored, but now everything is professional. Even a small misfield is discussed in meetings. That has made everyone responsible. We're ticking most boxes, and that's making a huge difference." Those words now resonate louder than ever.

Dishant Yagnik: *The Visionary*, the side's fielding coach, boldly predicted during the Buchi Babu tournament that his side would lift the trophy.

But Yagnik's vision stretches beyond one crown. "Yes, and I'll stand by it. I truly believe that JKCA will be the first team in Indian domestic cricket to win all three formats in a single season – Ranji Trophy, Vijay Hazare, and Syed Mushtaq Ali. Call it a vision, a dream, or a claim – but it's rooted in what I've seen: the players' mindset, the administration's support, and the overall attitude. When a team wants to win that badly, victory is not too far away".

THE GIST

Jammu & Kashmir is fierce, relentless and unapologetically serious about its cricket

Skipper Dogra represented Himachal Pradesh and Puducherry over a career spanning more than two decades. The seasoned campaigner finally realised a long-cherished dream – lifting the Ranji Trophy as captain of Jammu & Kashmir

Yagnik's vision stretches beyond one crown. He truly believes J & K will be the first team in Indian domestic cricket to win all three formats in a single season

Why key to coconut cultivation today is sustainability, not productivity

The ‘Coconut Promotion Scheme’ must not be limited to distributing high-yield seedlings but must prioritise the development and mass multiplication of climate-resilient varieties for farms along the east coast and in peninsular regions, and wilt-tolerant varieties for coconut-growing regions along the west coast

R. Ranjit Kumar

The 2026-27 Union Budget announced a ‘Coconut Promotion Scheme’ with the primary aim of improving productivity by rejuvenating old, non-productive gardens with high yielding coconut varieties and establishing new plantations along the coast. The farming community has welcomed the announcement.

The Coconut Development Board (CDB) is already implementing a similar scheme, which has helped rejuvenate old gardens and expanded cultivation into non-traditional areas, including in parts of Gujarat, Assam, and other non-peninsular regions – sufficient to partially offset the widespread destruction of coconut palms in Kerala and Tamil Nadu by disease.

Heat and disease

India is the world’s largest producer and consumer of coconuts. The domestic prices of coconut and tender coconut remain far higher than prevailing international prices even though the productivity per palm in India is already higher than in Sri Lanka, the Philippines, and Indonesia. In places like Anaimalai in Tamil Nadu, Dwarf x Tall hybrid palms regularly produce 250 to 300 tender coconuts per tree.

Today, climate change and disease are greater concerns than productivity. Research by the Central Plantation Crops Research Institute (CPCRI) has projected that temperatures in regions with plantations may rise by 1.6-2.1°C by 2050 and up to 3.2 °C by 2070. Higher temperature without a significant change in the rainfall levels will increase the vapour pressure deficit and intensify drought stress.

Studies have also found that large parts of interior peninsular India, including parts of Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh, along with the south interior region of Tamil Nadu and the east coasts could become less suitable for coconut cultivation in the coming decades as a result.

Expanded scope

The CPCRI has found that coconut can still be cultivated along the Western Ghats belt in Kerala, coastal Karnataka, and western Tamil Nadu even during the high temperature regimes. However, these regions are beset by root wilt disease; in Alappuzha and Pollachi districts, the coconut landscape has been completely devastated.

Therefore, the new ‘Coconut Promotion Scheme’ must not be limited to distributing high-yield seedlings but must prioritise the development and mass multiplication of climate-resilient varieties for farms along the east coast and in peninsular regions, and wilt-tolerant varieties for the traditional coconut-growing regions along the west coast.

Large tracts of land vested with the



A coconut farm at Poosaripatti near Pollachi in Coimbatore district. PERIASAMY M.

State horticulture departments and universities can be used to establish mother palm gardens. Similarly, the State should consider strengthening research in institutions like the CPCRI and the Tamil Nadu Agricultural University, so that they can identify and breed heat-tolerant, drought-resilient, and disease-resistant genotypes.

Farmer producer organisations (FPOs), cooperatives, and credible private nurseries should also be enabled to mass-produce these resilient seedlings.

The aspect of the scheme to enhance productivity entails distributing free or subsidised inputs. Many such schemes often distribute biological inputs, microbial formulations, micro-nutrients, etc. But in practice, they are often substandard or poorly stored, reducing the microbial viability.

Instead, the State should consider direct benefit transfers, since farmers must be trusted to decide whether they need irrigation systems, soil amendments, labour for rejuvenation or other improvements.

Failed take-off

The third area that merits a serious rethink is adding value. In many coconut-growing regions today, production barely meets strong domestic demand for culinary purposes. The domestic price of coconut has increased three-fold since 2024. Encouraging FPOs to invest in processing units during lean supply periods without also assuring them of marketing channels will only expose them to financial risk. The equipment already supplied under such schemes often lies idle.

The ‘Cluster Development Programme’ implemented by the National Horticulture Board (NHB) has an outlay of about ₹150

Studies show that parts of interior peninsular India, including Karnataka and A.P., along with southern T.N. and the east coast could be less suitable for coconut cultivation due to climate change and diseases

crore for three verticals: production, value addition, and marketing. However, the programme didn’t take off because its high investment barriers prevented FPOs and cooperatives from being meaningful participants as implementing agencies. Even after repeated stakeholder consultations and deadline extensions, private firms were not interested in being the implementing agencies.

The CDB is already implementing schemes that provide a 25% capital subsidy to the industry involved in coconut value addition, so there is no reason for them to subscribe to the same variant of the scheme implemented by the NHB, that too with numerous compliance requirements, including inspection and auditing regulations. The subsidy percentage also varies across the verticals, confusing farmers and investors alike.

The banana cluster in southern Tamil Nadu is another example of an enterprise that remains largely on paper.

Smaller but better

The government must evaluate these experiences in good faith, including by adopting fool-proof metrics to measure the success of schemes rather than resorting to official reports and stage-managed interactions with farmers.

Large, centrally designed clusters may not be the answer. Instead, smaller pilot

models anchored in a genuine cooperative spirit with hand-holding – for example, marketing partnerships with experienced FMCG players like Amul or ITC – could be tested in locations such as Tiptur (which grows ball copra), Anaimalai (tender coconuts), and Pollachi (coconut oil). Smaller but better designed projects can yield more useful lessons as well.

Dovetailing the ‘Coconut Promotion Scheme’ with the ‘Cluster Development Programme’ could also eventually help fund the multiplication of better coconut saplings.

Real crises

Farmers rarely have the institutional voice that large industries possess. Policies are often drafted based on official briefings rather than ground realities. A simple visit to affected areas like Alappuzha and Pollachi will reveal that root wilt disease is destroying livelihoods and that climate stress is no longer theoretical.

The ‘Coconut Promotion Scheme’ is an opportunity to study and develop climate-resilient and disease-resistant coconut varieties, and to acknowledge that enhancing productivity alone won’t secure the future. Climate resilience, wilt resistance, direct trust in farmers, and honest evaluation of past failures must guide implementation.

If these principles are adopted in full spirit, the scheme can protect India’s leadership in coconut cultivation for decades. If not, however, it will be yet another well-intentioned allocation that doesn’t address the real crises facing coconut cultivators.

(R. Ranjit Kumar is managing director, Pollachi Nutmeg Farmer Producer Company, and ICAR-IARI Innovative Farmer Awardee. ranjitkct@gmail.com)

THE GIST

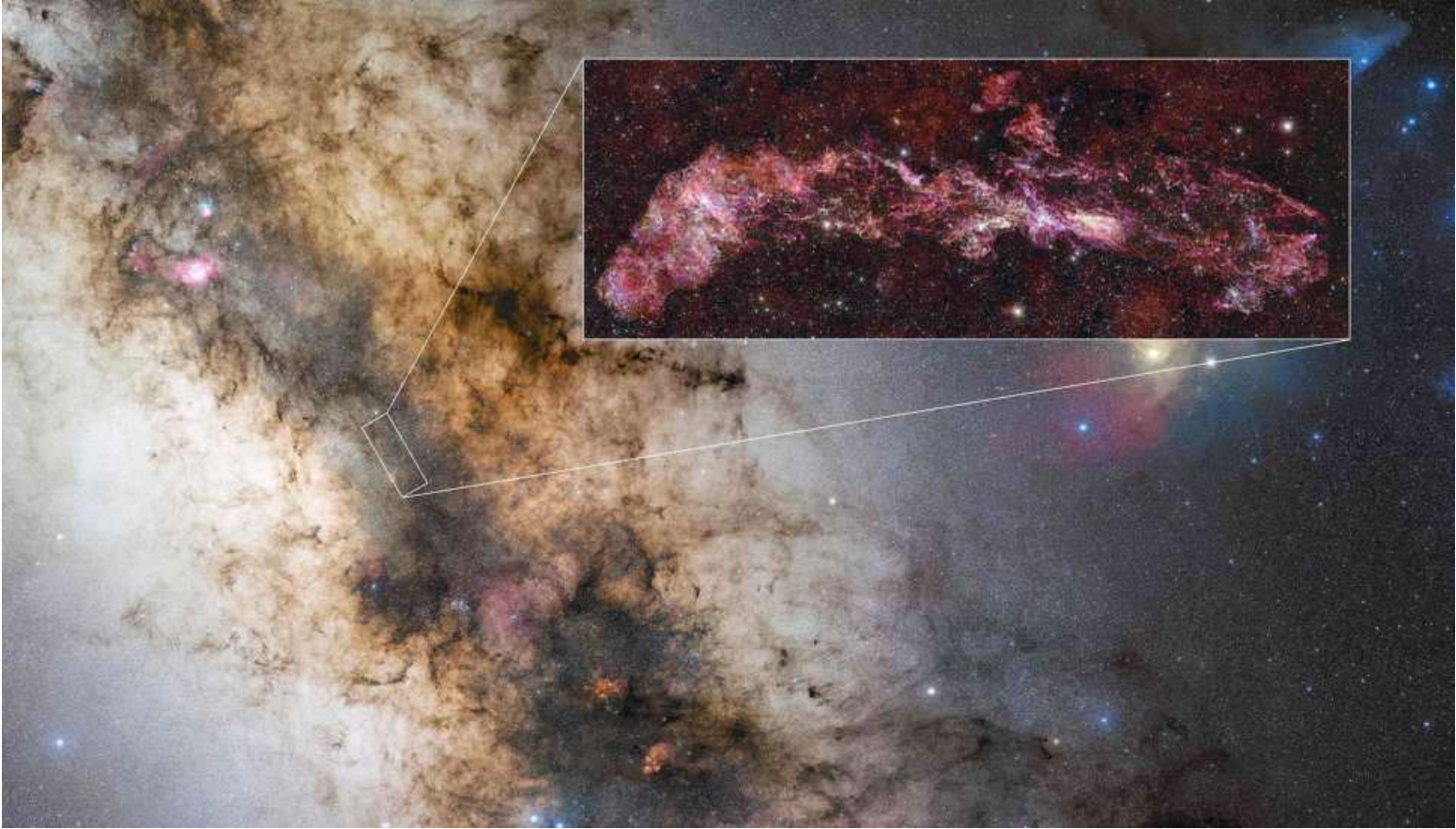
India is the world’s largest producer and consumer of coconuts. However, the domestic prices of coconut and tender coconut remain far higher than prevailing international prices

The 2026-27 Union Budget announced a ‘Coconut Promotion Scheme’ with the primary aim of improving productivity by rejuvenating old, non-productive gardens with high yielding coconut varieties and establishing new plantations along the coast

Today, climate change and disease are greater concerns than productivity for coconut cultivation in the country

Climate resilience, wilt resistance, direct trust in farmers, and honest evaluation of past failures must guide implementation of the scheme

BIG SHOT



The Atacama Large Millimeter/submillimeter Array (ALMA) has mapped the Central Molecular Zone, a region at the core of our galaxy rich in dense and intricate gas clouds; this image was released on February 26. Scientists have been able to observe this region of the Milky Way in detail for the first time, where star formation could provide keys to understanding the origins of the universe. AFP

WHAT IS IT?

Salar de Pajonales: Mars analogue

One of the best places to practice hunting for life on Mars could be in the Atacama Desert in Chile. Scientists recently studied the Salar de Pajonales, an incredibly dry and freezing salt flat located 3.5 km above sea level. Together with the fact that it is blasted by ultraviolet radiation, the Salar is a near-perfect analogue of the conditions on Mars.

The scientists focused on rocks made of gypsum, a mineral (CaSO₄.2H₂O) found on both earth and Mars. Specifically, they looked at layered rock structures built by microbes over long spans of time called stromatolites. They found that this mineral has acted like a protective shelter for life in the Salar in two ways.

First, they found living microbes hiding just millimetres beneath the rock’s surface. Because gypsum is translucent, it allows enough sunlight in for the microbes to subsist on but blocks harmful radiation and traps small amounts of moisture. The resulting conditions allow life to survive in an otherwise hostile environment. Second, deeper inside the stromatolites, the team found fossils and chemical fingerprints of ancient life, meaning after the microbes died, the gypsum



A view of the Salar de Pajonales from the International Space Station's Expedition 6. NASA

sealed their remains and preserved them.

The study is important because scientists know Mars has large deposits of gypsum, and orbiters and satellites could look there in future. If gypsum can protect microbes and preserve fossils in the earth’s most extreme desert, it is reasonable to think it could be holding secrets of ancient Martian life as well.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Science’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Percentage increase in Gross GST collection in February

8.1 in per cent. Gross GST collection increased by 8.1% to over ₹1.83 lakh crore in February, led by higher growth in revenues from imports and domestic sales. Gross domestic revenue rose 5.3% to about ₹1.36 lakh crore, while gross import revenue climbed 17.2% to ₹47,837 crore. PTI

International flights to West Asia cancelled by Pak. after Iran attack

184 At least 184 international flights of different airlines from Pakistan to West Asia have been cancelled since Saturday. International flights in West Asia have all been badly disrupted or suspended after the closure of the Dubai and Abu Dhabi airports. PTI

Worth of projects inaugurated in Madurai by PM

4,400 in ₹ crore. Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday also laid foundation stone for four-laning of Marakkanam-Puducherry section and Paramakudi-Ramanathapuram section of key NH routes. PTI

Number of calls received by NORKA helpdesk

381 A 24-hour helpdesk set up by NORKA Roots, following the Israel-Iran conflict, has received 381 calls till 11:30 a.m. on Sunday, officials said. It was established as per the direction of Chief Minister's Office to assist Non-Resident Keralites and their family members. PTI

Persons killed in a blast at explosives factory in Nagpur

18 At least 18 persons were killed and 20 others injured in a blast that tore through an explosives manufacturing factory in Maharashtra's Nagpur district on Sunday, police said. The blast took place at the SBL Energy Limited factory, a senior police official said. PTI
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Missile interceptors in U.S.-Iran war

How is this conflict different from the 12-day war? What is missile defence and how does it work? How effective are Iron Dome and Patriot systems? Can saturation attacks exhaust interceptors? What systems are Iran deploying?

EXPLAINER

Vasudevan Mukunth

The outbreak of fresh hostilities between the U.S.-led coalition, including Israel and the United Arab Emirates, and Iran seems to have triggered a newly integrated regional air defence network different from the one these actors deployed during their brief yet intense conflict in June last year.

The 12-day war in 2025 was until then the most significant test of the Integrated Air and Missile Defence, with the alliance faced with having to blunt retaliation by Iran that included more than 500 ballistic missiles and over twice as many 'suicide drones'. This time, with the theatre of conflict including the Persian Gulf, the UAE has brought to bear its South Korean defence system together with the debut of U.S. systems that were only prototypes last year.

While many of these systems showcase new abilities, they also highlight the U.S.' and Israel's need to 'ration' them to keep costs down and ensure they're still available should the conflict drag on.

What is missile defence?

Missile defence refers to a military system that finds and destroys incoming missiles before they hit their targets. These systems use sensors – including satellites in earth orbit and radar stations on the ground – to watch the sky and, when they spot an enemy missile, track its speed and direction.

Then, military command centres use powerful computers and military personnel to receive the data from the sensors and based on that calculate which targets the missile endangers and which response is most suitable. One important kind of response is the interceptor – which is a missile that flies towards the incoming threat with the purpose of destroying it.

In addition to saving lives and property, missile defence can discourage enemies from starting conflicts that could require missiles, since the interceptors could render them ineffective, as well as give leaders more time to deliberate.

How an interceptor works

Let's use the example of the U.S. Patriot system, which consists of several components connected by cables or wireless data links.

Its radar unit remains stationary on the ground rather than spinning, like the radar you see in airports. It steers thousands of radio beams across the sky to scan for objects. When these beams hit an aircraft or incoming missile, they bounce back to the radar and a computer analyses the returning signals to estimate the object's speed, location, altitude, and direction.

If the object is deemed to be a threat, a connected computer can concentrate the radar's energy at that point in the sky. Such focused tracking is called a lock, and in this condition the radar will update the target's position continuously.

Meanwhile, the computers at the Engagement Control Station (ECS), a mobile command centre operated by soldiers, calculate the trajectory of the object and determine when to fire a counter-measure. When the system commands a launch, a signal goes to a launcher truck, which ignites the rocket motor of an interceptor. As the interceptor lifts off, the ground radar will continue to track both the target and the missile simultaneously. The ECS will compare the positions of both objects and



An interceptor flies in the sky as missiles from Iran are fired to Israel, as seen from Tel Aviv. FILE PHOTO

send commands to the interceptor to guide it through the air.

In the final seconds of flight, the interceptor will use its onboard seeker – a component that acts like its driver – to find the target. Since interceptors often move at multiple times the speed of sound, seekers have to be very precise. The interception itself can happen in one of two ways. Older missiles use a proximity fuse that senses when the target is nearby and blows up a powerful warhead, destroying the object with shrapnel. Newer interceptors are hit-to-kill: the missile steers itself directly into the body of the target, using the kinetic energy of the collision to shatter it.

The radar observes the impact to confirm the target has been destroyed before resetting to engage the next threat.

How effective are interceptors?

The efficacy of an interceptor varies depending on the target.

The short-range rockets that Israel uses as part of its 'Iron Dome' system is effective against simple, slow-moving rockets, with the country reporting 80-97% success rates in recent conflicts.

The U.S. Patriot system on the other hand deals with targets moving much faster and is less successful in absolute terms. For example, in May 2023, about a year after Russia's invasion of Ukraine had begun, Patriot had 100% success against six Russian Kinzhal hypersonic missiles on one night over Kyiv and more than 60% against the Iskander-M ballistic missiles.

After that, Russia modified Iskander-M to release decoys and make sharp turns through the air just before it strikes. Russia has also been launching larger groups of missiles and drones at once. So even if a Patriot battery has a high success rate, it only carries a limited number of interceptors. Altogether, its rate has reportedly dropped to around 10% since.

According to the Center for Arms Control and Non-Proliferation, "The only programme designed to protect the entire United States homeland from a long-range missile attack is the GMD [Ground-based Midcourse Defence] programme. GMD has a failing test record: a success rate of just 55% in highly scripted tests, including three misses in the last six tries."

What makes Cheongung II different?

In the ongoing conflict, the UAE has

activated a missile defence involving the South Korean Cheongung II missiles while the alliance has been using the Terminal High Altitude Area Defence (THAAD) and the Patriot batteries supplied by the U.S. The UAE acquired Cheongung from South Korea to intercept low-flying Iranian cruise missiles and tactical ballistic missiles over the Gulf.

These missiles use a hit-to-kill technology similar to the U.S. Patriot system but are also optimised for threats in the Persian Gulf.

A missile launched from coastal Iran can reach the UAE within minutes. Older versions of Patriot used radars that scanned for objects in a 120° cone. If a threat came from outside this cone, the battery had to physically rotate, losing precious seconds. Cheongung II however uses a 'Vertical Launch System' fit with a rotating multi-function radar that can fire in 360° without moving the launcher.

Missiles called "skimmers" can fly just above the surface of the Gulf's waters to stay under the radar's view, so the Cheongung II missile is also equipped with a radar in its nose, which it turns on in the final seconds of flight to not have to depend on the ground radar as it approaches impact.

How does cost shape interceptor use?

While the U.S. relied heavily on its expensive Patriot defence system during the June 2025 conflict, it has deployed its new Indirect Fire Protection Capability to protect bases in the UAE and Kuwait. This system uses AIM-9X Sidewinder missiles as interceptors and helps with rationing Patriot.

Patriot's cost is relevant because Iran's strategy, called a saturation attack, has been to fire a flurry of cheap missiles to exhaust the alliance's interceptors. The system's PAC-3 Missile Segment Enhancement (MSE) interceptors however cost around \$4 million per shot.

The U.S. Navy has deployed SM-6 missiles in their 'dual' configuration, in which they can intercept ballistic missiles in their terminal phase as well as Iranian fast-attack craft.

Finally, after Israel introduced it during the 12-day war, the country's 'Iron Beam' high-energy laser has become the primary defence against drone swarms. As with the U.S. and Patriot, Iron Beam is reportedly allowing Israel to ration its Arrow 3 and Stunner.

What changed after the 12-day war?

During the 12-day war, the first line of defence comprised the Israeli Arrow 3 system and U.S. Navy destroyers with SM-3 missiles. Arrow 3 engaged medium-range ballistic missiles in space, before they reentered the atmosphere, although the intensity of the barrage rapidly depleted Israeli stockpiles by the second week of the conflict. Likewise U.S. destroyers in the Red and the Mediterranean Seas recorded the heaviest use of the SM-3 missiles in combat until then.

The endo-atmospheric defence system used U.S. THAAD batteries and Israel's legacy Arrow 2 system. Then came Israel's David Sling with its Stunner interceptors, with Patriot forming the last line.

Against the 'suicide drones', the alliance used the 'Iron Dome' and its Tamir interceptors and 'Iron Beam', with help from air to air missiles fired by the U.S. Air Force and Navy, the Royal Air Force, and France's Rafales.

As of January this year, an important focus area for the U.S. and its allies was to replenish the expended munitions. The U.S. Department of Defence has already quadrupled production orders for THAAD and PAC-3 MSE interceptors and has accelerated the deployment of directed-energy systems to naval vessels.

This said, "Production of all munitions – interceptors for THAAD, Patriot, Arrow, David's Sling, and Iron Dome... – is far slower than current combat use or anticipated future high-intensity war requirements," Charles Corcoran and Ari Cicurel wrote in *RealClearDefence* in January 2026. Maj. Gen. Corcoran is a former chief of staff of the U.S. Air Forces Central Command and Cicurel is the associate director of foreign policy at the Jewish Institute for National Security of America.

They added that "Replenishing THAAD shortages ... will take at least 1.5 years at current production capacity" and that U.S. manufacturing has "not scaled for high-tempo operations in decades".

How strong is Iran's air and missile defence network?

Iran's most advanced interceptor is an upgraded version of the Bavar-373 system using the Sayyad-4B missile, reportedly designed to intercept targets at ranges exceeding 300 km. Iran also recently unveiled its Arman Ballistic Missile Defence system, which it has said is optimised to intercept short- to medium-range ballistic missiles with 360° radar coverage.

To counter cruise missiles as well as F-35 and F-15 fighter jets, the military is using the Sevom-e-Khordad missile system. It's highly mobile, which means it can fire from one place and quickly relocate to another, making it harder for U.S. forces to destroy its radars. Iran is reportedly using Sayyad-3 missiles with this system to protect its Natanz and Isfahan nuclear facilities.

With reports of strikes in Tehran, Iran is also using the Russia-made Tor-M1 short-range missiles to intercept precision-guided bombs and the Majid and Azarakhsh systems to counter low-flying drones and cruise missiles.

This said, reports of explosions in Tehran and Isfahan indicate the U.S. and Israeli barrage could be overwhelming Iran's interceptors with sheer volume. This is possible because once a battery fires one batch of around six missiles, it needs to reload, leaving the site defenceless until then. The Bavar-373 system's purported ability to detect stealth aircraft has also been in question since the alliance has struck targets in Tehran.

THE GIST

▼ The outbreak of fresh hostilities has triggered a newly integrated regional air defence network, with the UAE activating Cheongung II and the U.S. deploying prototype systems alongside Patriot and THAAD.

▼ Interceptors such as PAC-3 MSE, SM-6 and AIM-9X are being rationed amid saturation attacks, as production remains far slower than current combat use.

▼ Iran is using Bavar-373, Arman BMD, Sevom-e-Khordad and Tor-M1 systems, but sheer volume and reload gaps may be overwhelming its interceptors.

